THIS IS HOW YOU LOSE ETHERIA

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30664229.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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F/F

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), This is How You Lose the Time War - Amal El-Mohtar & Max Gladstone

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Hordak (She-Ra), Adora & Angella (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Time Travel, Multiple Realities, original lore, various allusions to philosophy, read the conspiracy against the human race by thomas ligotti and this all makes more sense i promise, also hegel and stirner i guess, Slow Burn, not even really a slow burn because its not that long but like kinda, Mean Lesbians, mean as in they kill people fr

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THIS IS HOW YOU LOSE ETHERIA

by hazelspacecadet

Summary

"Look upon my works, ye mighty, and despair!"
Catra is an agent in time, at the whim of a war that rages eternally without meaning.
Adora is a killing machine running on empty, fed up with a temporal-galactic spree of violence.
Catra leaves Adora a letter in the ruins of a battlefield, and Adora responds.
The rest isn't history, but the future and past colliding.

Notes

before you read any further: cw for lots of stuff!
this fic features murder, graphic portrayals of gore/violence, allusions to transphobia (as written by a trans person aka Me) and explicit language, as well non-sexually described nudity. if you are uncomfortable with any of that, particularly the violence, i'd recommend not reading. chapters with unique content warnings will be tagged individually in case you just want to skip them.

also it has art by the wonderful mofnmancer ! its embedded throughout the text at the right points but you can also check out her twitter @7RC3Productions for the art on its own.

woooohh boy this is a big one for the big bang. 30k ish of wild, untamed on-the-fly lore, an approximate adjacency to she-ra and my own structural inspiration from the fantastic novel this is how you lose the time war, plus some sad sad girls in space/time. i hope you enjoy!

TWO HEADED GIRL

At the incident of their birth, Catra is given two things. A name - which she handily ignores - and the illusion of free will.

To compensate, Adora is given two names - one of which they hate - and hardwired with purpose and deft coldness.

In wires and out of time, in a castle that never crumbles, in a garden that never wilts, The Horde reproduces and wanders through and under space. For every planet infested, for every disease propagated, for every crimson shade hewn in the shadows of petty galactic god-games, a red leaf grows on the highest free branch of a tree. It stands in the black hole, the haptic void, at the centre of the universe. And slowly, the veins of the things are starting to come alive.

A darkly dressed, haunted looking man called Ligotti came to the Horde some eons ago with glowing dust in a jar in his coat pocket. The Horde welcomed him with open arms and unsheathed swords, believing him to be either a madman or a genius, prophesying relentlessly of an impossible end time, a violation of the quiet plan. Ligotti explained that his jar contained the remains of his friend, Phillipp, who had told him of this great violation moments before his death. Ligotti was killed not ten minutes later when he threatened to plug the dust into The Horde itself and create a being unlike that ever seen before, with the key to the rest of Phillipp's remains and thus the energy needed to shift the end times towards the plan. Ligotti was killed because he did not explain anything. The remains were stored away in a vault in the ever-castle and bled slowly into the creation of things millions of years down the line.

In space and free of causality, in a mansion that never sees the picket mob, in the internet cafe of all existence, Brightmoon recalibrates itself upon every blow The Horde strikes. The Eternal Moon at the universe's heart is a cosmic telescope that tracks every leaf, every frail, veined thing blowing in a wind that cannot

be. “Se rabat sur”, the great relation, the ocean subsuming the corpses, a tender caress of pointed rock in mind.

A prophet who went only by the name of The Mainlander died a hundred years ago. Around his remains, or what remained of them, was left a journal, a sword and a wetware tracker usually belonging to agents of Brightmoon. Those who found the preserved half of his body believed him a petty murderer and madman; those who read his journal came to know a runaway agent, an evangeliser of the end times and most undeniably a madman. His journal foretold that there would be no foretelling: the apocalypse would come in fits and starts, the universe would be consumed piece by piece in orgasmic horror, and at the centre of the thing would stand a tyrannical relation. Two things, two people, two minds. He saw vividly something that was twice itself, and died with one of his eyes ripped out.

The Mainlander’s corpse remained an object of debate and controversy in the halls of Brightmoon, under the pretense that no word should escape to The Horde. On the other side of eternity, The Horde had its perfect player; it had Phillipp’s completion machine.

They meet for the first time in a painted, ashen forest, some time past the present. Adora’s eyes, all ocean-marine-bright-soul blue, bluer than the suns raging at the heart of the cosmos, ensnared in the great divide of Catra’s teal and orange. She’s come prepared: claws hang by her hip, teeth glimmer in an impossible moonlight, and Adora is quietly anticipating a bloody, furious decomposition at the hands of this midnight devil.

She knows immediately something is wrong with the girl at the other end of the clearing. That she is broken, severed and damaged, that something about her needs to fit somewhere. The forest and the leaves rustle into the halls of eternity, a resonance designed to stick.

There’s a smile that rings forever, two flashes and the blur of an overcoat, and Adora’s body is slashed and broken amongst the

leaves. A pity, she was so pretty today.

SYMMETRY/CUTE THING

Chapter Summary

PART 1 - SYMMETRY
Adora goes to war. Catra lurks in the corpses.
PART 2 - CUTE THING
Catra shows off. Adora shows up.

There's a war going on.

Well, there sort of always is, somewhere. If somewhere is a good translation of "*fucking everywhere*", then Adora supposes she knows nothing but war. She's greeted at the gate of Brightmoon by a wordless drone, having been briefed earlier by her supervisor. Beyond the gate is a series of corridors, their gravity-defying angle changes sprawling out beyond the reach of Adora's vision. The drone equips her for a bloody mission, vacates what will soon become an airlock of sorts, and soon Adora is reaching out to a great time spiral, to be carried deep into the violent web of Strands that composes the war's understanding of the universe.

There's a war going on. There are petty discrepancies and the wills or whims of kings to contend with, the religious fervour of the democratic evangelists or the guerilla tyrants. Adora knows every war, every disagreement, the sanctum of promises written in young men's blood and what-will-you's, and it's all *boring* .

She's plummeting through non-space, her Hegelian diametric meter momentarily freaking out as she takes a sharp twist towards Strand #3776, the exact locale of a brutal interplanetary war. She can track through time like a hunting dog, so long as nothing changes, so long as she stays in line. Her imperative is simple: do some war crimes, hide the evidence, maneuvering yet another star system into the ineffable place that her superiors require in the process, and leave with great haste. They will watch her every move, track her decisions numerically, and report back to her for mindless improvement. But it shouldn't be hard. This

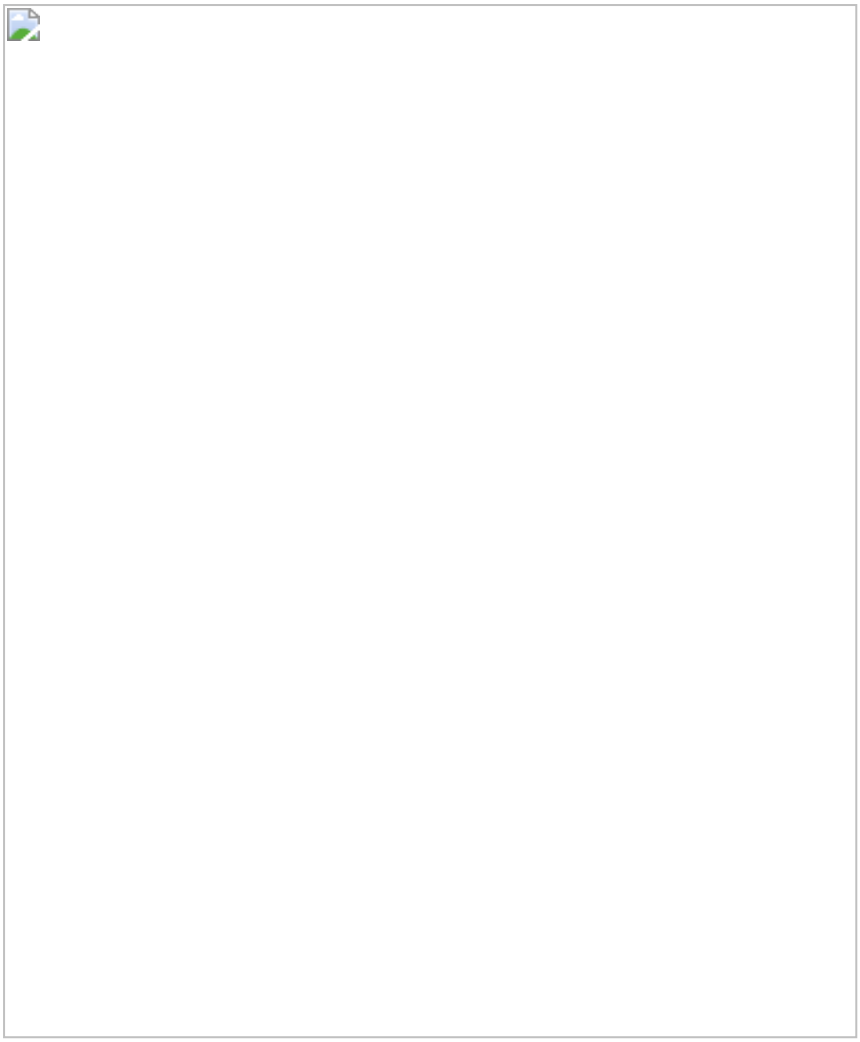
mission is guaranteed free of interference, supposedly. But she knows The Horde lurks, in the back alleys of chaos and the festering underworlds of violence. She supposes she's prepared.

And there's a war going on. She's tired and feisty, a reluctant spectre on the battlefield. She strips an army of their godly flags and their worldly mortalities with a swiftness and a purpose enabled specifically by the high-stakes nature of her mission, and not at all by her own fetishes. These men have to die, have to scream their hearts out on a planet that has seen time pass for longer than they could reckon with, that is dying under the weight of a God and a war and ten million guns pointed at the grizzled faces of would-be-lovers and poets, losers and leaders. It's not so bad when you look at it that way.

She lets her body guide her through the waves of soldiers. Is this really the state of things? No agency, no shape, no power. Endless bodies as a site of power, The Horde and Brightmoon pushing their ineffable schemes throughout the galaxy as forces that act because they must act. Everything happens because it does, and everything Adora considers feels trite and worthless a moment later. For a killing machine, senseless murder puts her in an awful mood.

She's just carved out the brains from the skull of a persistent foot soldier when her vision catches on a shadow in the ashen wastes of what was once an army camp. The fizzing wires and sparks from ghostly machines were supposed to enclose nothing but a pleasant hollowness; Adora is familiar with the aftermath of a war near the end of time, loves the electric hum a little too much. But there's a spectre of spectres in the wash of agonies faded, the smirk of something too fucking *alive* mangling bone and ash, a queen of zombies and bane of Adora's existence. The Horde wasn't fucking supposed to find shit here, despite her superiors' promises - this was a mission of some personal importance, not that Adora is much in the game of differentiation - so why of all people did it have to be *her* scuffing the corpses to life?

After the job is done, the great green swath of land that Adora was dropped on now a deep, violent brown, the kind of brown that speaks of pockmarks and bullet holes, of strewn bodies and festering pools of the kind of ooze that dead people make as a final fuck you, she decides in her mind to never return here ever. The nuclear option was never really on her to-do list. That necrotic bitch forced her hand. The zombies raged and raged for hours, great gangly gutless things, all cracked bone and ill fitting armour. Tailors tend to work in service of the living; even here, where the calling card that Adora hates to have seen before can rear its ugly techno-necrotic head and ruin a clean run, precluding a neat path for a Strand that Adora has manicured, since the inauguration of her agent-hood, into perfection. As she surveys the scene, ready to return with lead in her soul, a glimmer of a little living thing strikes her off-balance, not that she ever falls over. She flashes down back to the rotting, collapsing dirt to find a flower at the centre of what must have been an impossible carnage. The petals are crimson, not with blood but beauty, and Adora doesn't know what to feel. The side she killed first was an iridescent gold; the second side was all deep blues and purples, oddly enough the colours of home. So why this red? She picks the flower gently - it wasn't stuck all that deep - and returns through the Strands, clutching a message from a distant soul.



Look upon my works, ye mighty, and despair!

And you did, didn't you, and all of their entrails sprayed across the floor!

I don't mean to tease, darling. Besides, we barely even know *each other. Hello babe, I'm Catra. We do seem to see a lot of each other, and I just thought how* awfully *dull this would all get if I couldn't gloat about wanton destruction to the only other really living thing for miles and years. Surely, what would even be the point of our superiors assigning us so much of the same Strands if I wasn't gonna get you to flirt back? And you did look so pretty covered in all that blood.*

So what do you like? I'm a fan of long walks on the beach, covert operations across time/space and maybe someday, getting to beat

the shit out of you. I can feel you glaring, or saying "ooh what a cocky bitch", but I know you're the same. Colder maybe, a little more shiny than I am, ornate and shimmery. I get all the doldrums and dusty crevices, you see. The Horde makes me out of steadfast iron and human gore, matte surfaces or rotted weeds. It makes the business of disassembly and reassembly all too easy on these missions. How about you? Oh, it doesn't matter. It's so appealing to see one so in tune with the sun, the light passing. You must hate the haptic void. I love it. There, that's another thing I love. All consuming voids at the axiomatic point of space/time. So romantic.

Speaking not of romance but of bloodshed, there's something wrong with you, isn't there. I can feel it. The gore spilling outwards, the universe rushing in. I'm intrigued.

Best wishes for our next fight, darling.

Love and prayers (sorry, my brain sticks to the god-botherers),

Catra

And like clockwork, she's out again. Her form unravelling down a sought out path in the cosmos, the strings of time only an array of calculations and operations in her decomposed mind, Catra carries out her travels with purpose and swiftness. She is the daughter of someone great, someone irrelevant, alone at a party without meaningful justification, Catra is resplendent in shock red and Catra is waving a tail in the faces of onlookers. It's all her, baby; the ego boost of vacant eyes in adoration, the quiet stare of a child who gets blessed with her acknowledgement. The Horde never gives her these missions very often, wants her cold and murderous, an instant result at the proverbial desk. When they mythologise Ligotti, the spectre in the court of the king, that's what they use him for. The Horde is bad at stories, but great at propaganda, mainly because you suffer if you don't agree, and you're never sure how exactly to agree. So Ligotti is a name for the superstitious and the wise, the living and the suffering. She

treats it with indifference. It's a shame then, because infecting these kinds of violent, fawning social spheres in the way he supposedly loved is all kinds of fun. She walks down the red carpet and towards a stifling hot hall, the threat of applause and eyelid flutters filling the air. She's the actor amongst actors, looking as believably *there* as possible until the time comes to fade into the background and keep this sweaty, fatty pity party tumbling down the creek of the socius.

The concert hall hired for this most ornate and useless of occasions is huge. She's not really bothered to research her case closely, and The Horde only gives her the essentials, so she assumes that nothing is needed of her beyond quiet observation. She'll get around the place and make sure nothing out of the ordinary is happening; The Horde likes these vapid caverns of culture, likes how event photos spread inadequacies through the minds of those watching. It has to go smoothly.

Her hands spend the first half of the evening colliding in exact time, and the nerve endings have gone slightly dead. In the bathroom, her absence excused with a grin and a flash of tail, her ears swivel to meet the creaking and creeping of the vast backstage. She latches onto a twice-resonant clang and ghosts free from the cubicles with ease. Catra breaks down the cubicle door in a flash and slides out into the maze of backstage corridors. A single, razor-sharp nail bypasses a locked door through which she is almost certain lies her prize. The clicking sound as it creaks up into the dark backstage area warrants a nasty smirk. There's nothing much in the shadows: the clutter of busy work, the murmurings of anticipation, a gentle roar from the main hall, but Catra knows that there is a lurking thing just beyond her. A cold, dead, isolated thing, a blue smell and a moon-like footstep. She rests on her feet, deftly shifted into the raised stance of a hunter, the smooth skin having become fur and rough, leathery pads. There's a toothy smirk, a wet nose and unsheathed claws, all mechanically deployed, all immaculate, all honed on a familiar resonating coldness. A growl escapes her and-

"Hey, uhh, miss? Should you be back here?"

The voice is dead and empty as the eyes outside. Her hunting stance pulls back inwards in an instant.

“Who, me? Oh, not really. Do you know where the bathroom is?” Catra says through gritted fangs. She forgot to put those away.

“Just through that door and to the left. Wait- how did you- it’s locked?” A shadowed pair of hands gesture to the door through which Catra came.

“Doesn’t matter, you cunt. We’re about to be blown to shreds. Say something nice for your family.”

“Wh-”

Catra curses the ashen sky, her body broken amidst an impossible wreckage. Timber, concrete and plasterboard, all married for one orgasmic second in the explosion, have made her a tender nest as she lies and waits to be extracted. Curse this fucking Strand. Curse that cold, hardened bitch and her white and blue face. Catra doesn’t even know how she saw a face so hidden in the shadows, when it was probably already fleeing the scene. When there’s no reason for the flash of consciousness that kept her out of the worst of the shredded debris to have hyper focused on a body long since lost into the night. When her whole brain had shut down just a moment later, just before the screaming. She groans through the reminder of how to feel pain, shutting off the worst of the flashing lights in her head, diving through her nervous system to warn of shattered bones and internal bleeding, a tail cut neatly down the centre and one battered, malfunctioning ear. She groans more audibly at the thought of The Horde running her through ineffable machinery for longer than she can stomach, until she’s newer again, better, bigger, faster, more focused. And she groans one last time when she notices a folded note atop a small pile of dust, just tempting the corners of her vision.

Dearest Catra,

You didn't even address me in your letter! How impolite. I hate when a gentleman is rude to the lady he wants to court, out of some masculine conviction. Yes, yes, I know, you prefer the feminine too, I just hate all the bravado. Anyways, I thought your letter deserved my politeness and due response, given all the effort it must have taken to lay a flower in a shitheap like that. You're quite the enigma, really. That tail is such a turn on, but I'm not sure about the claws. Little too wild for my tastes.

So, about the award ceremony. I'm awfully sorry. I mean, you know how it is. We've got jobs to do, and what does it matter if I was just a little quicker than you? I certainly didn't do anything naughty, like planting people backstage or putting children in crowds. You're above that - or, then again, I doubt there's very much that's too low for you. Did you like the explosion? Best of what I could cobble together at such short notice, especially after how tired I was from last time. I'll let you in on a little secret: Brightmoon is no good at preparing us. Seriously! I go out on missions without properly functioning pain receptors half the time. After what you said about, what was it, being assembled from steadfast iron and human gore, I can't imagine you're much happier about what The Horde does for you. Or to you, I should say.

And please don't construe me as the hero, you as the villain, though I know you'd love it. We blow up buildings to hurt people, not to save culture. Those roles aren't ours to play, and you don't deserve such moralising. I'm a fucking bastard like you. Perhaps there'll be a next time, and we can find out which one of us is more interested in killing, and which just enjoys the ride. That's our role to play. Reluctancy.

I hope your hands and fingers don't fail and you can take all this in. The note, as I'm sure you can tell by now, is empty - the paper texture should be an efficient relay now, or ever again. Maybe you went blind and deaf in the explosion and this little trick of mine was all too useful. Not that I'm even sure you want a letter back. Maybe you're just a hapless flirt?

Either way, best wishes, dear Catty Catra. We simply must meet again. I'll fuck you up royally.

Adora

HAWAII/ASSISTED HARAKIRI

Chapter Summary

PART 1 - HAWAII
Adora panics in the desert. Catra gets to win.
PART 2 - ASSISTED HARAKIRI
Catra finds sadness. Adora finds her own victory.

On the surface of a forgotten Earth, Adora waits. It's her first mission since the award ceremony incident, which, despite what to her mind was a resounding success, brought a pestilent fear into the endless strategising of her supervisors, one that kept her holed up in Brightmoon, barely corporeal. They've let her out again on a tracking mission; as the agent of the day with the most knowledge of (and personal investment in) any opposition entity, it is both risky and bountiful to set her in pursuit. Catra (she's nervous about that name; she gets the sense it is not hers to have yet) is elusive, subtle, brutal. She's all warm, pulsating energy, yet all crimson and deathly still. None of the blood in her veins belongs to her - Adora can find all the accidental donors and lost souls who got in the way traced along her arm. Not that she stares. Right now, her signature is concealed, her observations reduced to irritating bio-wetware mechanisations. Catra sits two tables across from her in a stifled, dust-covered restaurant. Why she's here is a mystery, and Adora is good at those. The mystery of the Mainlander, and why his name keeps returning, accompanied by hushed voices, in Brightmoon corridors comes to mind, though Adora immediately recognises that it is not the right time. This Earth is dying, dead even; it's hot and dusty everywhere, and what was a version of southern Italy feels like the Sahara. The waitress has a full face mask and passes Adora a drink enclosed by cheap, likely scavenged plastic. It goes warm and thick down her throat. Catra gets up, walks to a window, looks at what must be nothing for 55 seconds, then returns to her seat. Adora's skin is ever cold, but her hands are now shimmering with sweat. The drink is not doing well in her stomach. Catra is looking almost anxiously at the menu on the wall, then at the

waitress, then at the thatch roof. Her split colour eyes are almost too distinctive, as if they aren't really concerned with the ambient lighting. Adora swears she can hear a ticking sound, then a scream, then-

"Hey, Adora."

"It's always explosions!"

Adora doesn't know how Catra made it to her table in the dust and debris, but she's not having it. As the rage and uproar of desert calms, some nasty-looking gang reveals itself at the front door, storming through the kitchen and taking swift knives to the throats of employees. Adora tackles one of them as they go to open the chest of some trembling, worm-looking girl, placing her own knife firmly in the bandit's heart. Clambering up and over the fresh corpse, Adora spots the central hub of the gang's movement - a short, scaly man with a sawed off shotgun hanging by his side. There's a gentle purity to her next movements; a quiet dash through the kitchen door, one leap to the side to avoid whatever manner of projectile meets her entrance, a second, stronger leap towards a bulky bandit who falls under her blade, married to the efficient breaking of another's arm as they move towards an instinctive protective wild swipe, then a calibration of her stance in front of the other gang members for just a second until she picks up speed again, eviscerating one particularly bold challenger who moves forward just a second late and is rewarded with an unseaming from the nave to the chaps. Then the shotgun fire starts, coming in violent bursts, and Adora recovers herself with enough grace behind an upturned table until the familiar clicking of an empty gun resounds and she bursts from behind cover, streaking across the room and leaving a bleeding, screaming body behind her.

The applause, unsurprisingly, is surprising.

"Well played, babe. I was expecting that to go a lot better. Now you've made my life difficult."

“Why the fuck did a gang just, show up? What’s your game plan here?”

“Remember, nothing’s too low for me. I need this Earth in collapse mode until everything is fucking dead.”

“Then I guess I’m obliged to stop you.”

“Eh. Sure. Dance?

“What?”

“Dance with me, weird half-stranger.”

“A little rude-”

And with that, Catra takes her first blinding steps. Twice towards the corner of the room, once to turn in a flamenco flourish towards Adora, and a third to meet her knife with a hot blade of her own, a serrated, half-living thing with a bloodlust all of its own.

Two steps fast to the left, a flash of the knife, takes itself fast past Adora’s diving body.

Sharp and suddenly she’s in behind, the blade calling itself to her spine.

Adora spins around and takes Catra’s head in her arms, flipping her into a table.

The force resounds around the room. Splinters and dust in her eyes.

Everything is quickly a blur. Her tendons like violin strings, Catra’s face a dark angel of death.

There’s a crack. The bones in Adora’s neck.

An elbow right on the point where it turns.

A tear.

The tear spreads itself out upon contact with Adora's prostate body. It spells out the last words this particular incident of consciousness will know.

Dear Princess Charming,

I sure didn't want it to go this way. Our first dance! I know we've barely met but when a girl can't resist, the show goes ahead.

Oh, and that's what they call you, isn't it? Princesses? The royal *agents of the* royal *defenders of the* royal *cosmos. Guess what, sweetie? Your cosmos is fucking shit. It's a mess, frankly. You leave genocide behind you and brutality in front of you. We might be looking to end things too, but we do it with honesty. It's the kinder deal, despite what you might say, because I know it's bad, and hell I even cared once, and then I realised caring never did jack shit for a gunshot wound or my own conscience.*

Damn. This letter got pissed off real quick. It's not like I'm alone there. I have my cheat codes and my spies, but The Horde doesn't care. As long as everything's working - and it is.

You know, I read something a while back that I think is pertinent to our last dance there. It's called Last American Hero, regaling some forgotten mythos on some forgotten Strand. Here's an excerpt:

AS THE DESERT CLOUDS ROLL ON OVER HIS METAL SLAVE. SHE SUBMITS TO BE PARKED AND THE SHADOW OF LOVE IS AMOUNG THEM. A BLACKTOP TUMBLEWEED ROLLS AROUND THE DRIED TAR ONLY A DREAM OF IT'S MASTER BLOWING IN THE WIND.

To be a dream blowing in the wind! That's you, isn't it? I've heard all sorts. Rumours get around.

I hope we see each other again soon. You've had it this time.

The global desert sends its regards,

Catra

Catra *hates* the rules. As soon as you start messing with time, the instability of your own interactions advances exponentially, or so her boss Hordak always reminds her. Their bodies are built with hard limits, but regardless she finds ways to test and stretch them. And the centre of her whole deal is that she doesn't have one; she finds herself sick to the stomach at Hordak's raving and postulating on the furthering of the war, the spread of chaos, or some such bullshit. So she disconnects from the whole deal, sticks her head steadfast into the missions she gets given, and tunes out Hordak even on the good days. Today, praise be, is one of those, as she finds herself presented with a mission prompt that does not stick to the rules. She gets to die.

When an agent passes on in the material sense, they are still held together by their spirit, a sort of force that permeates material reality but does not consist exclusively within it, and maintains consciousness precisely because it is pre-existent to consciousness. This was explained to Catra a long time ago, but until now it had rarely been useful except to remind her of her own irritating pseudo-immortality. So now, thanks to her equally infuriating perfect memory, the intricacies of post-material mechanics, as they are so tautologically labelled by The Horde, are streaming back to the front of her mind. And what shit ' *mechanics* ' they are! All too abstracted. Catra loves the real, the tangible, but strangely it is this metaphysical prompt in front of her that has set her mind free. These are girls, killing themselves again and again, in some sort of euphoric feedback spiral, and she gets to *play along* . It's a strange joy, anticipating a torrent of emotions so complex it may just scare her off, but a joy nonetheless. Now, if only that damned blue-eyed girl doesn't show up, she might know peace to couple her happiness with. Sure, she said she'd see her soon. But whether she meant it escapes her own immediate thoughts. There was a lot of conflict in the quote she used, and she's sure Adora noticed.

Catra purges that name from her mind, only for now, as she prepares to depart the Horde. Only for now. Or forever, part of her wishes. She gets like that around others, stuck in halves. With Hordak she's stuck between killing him or letting the merciful side of her take over to just beat him senseless. A pretty pleasant dilemma to have, she thinks. And maybe these are her own rules, laws she follows so unconsciously that no reasonable politician would want to call them laws, more like values or citizen's duty, the unspoken legislative imperative of living in her own head. But fuck it, that's for a darker day. The mission at hand presents itself, in the form of a crying girl on a bathroom floor.

She made it to the world without even really noticing, but now she has to take it all in. The cold bathroom, a girl's bathroom she hopes, the slender, shell-shocked girl sobbing at her feet.

"You okay there?"

"Get out!" She lashes out, obviously without thinking, and Catra has to remind herself that she isn't fighting anything today.

"What's wrong? Crying girls make me stressed out. I wanna pee." Catra decides to play it casual. Not worth letting the cat out of the bag yet.

"Crying girls. Crying girls?"

"Well, it seems so."

"They called me a boy!"

"Do you mind?"

"I think so."

"Then that sucks. Are you gonna lie there crying while I pee, or-"

"Wait. I- I came in here to- you're dead too." It's a strange leap of logic to make, but then again, there isn't anywhere much stranger to do it.

“I sure hope not. Are you?”

“I sure hope so. But I’m- I’m unhappy. Fuck!”

“Well, it isn’t your fault, from what I can tell.”

“No, but- the girls are supposed to love it. That’s what they say.”

“And why do *they* say *that* ?”

“It makes them happy. The Policemen want to make the girls happy. And I went into the bathroom to pee, and they called me names, so I decided to prove them wrong. And now I’m more upset. It hurts!”

“It really does. What names did they call you?”

“Wait, but you-” Catra nods slightly to move the crying girl towards the right part of her question. “They called me my name. Michael.”

“I don’t think that’s your name.”

“How would you know?”

“Well, you cried when you heard it. I don’t do that at mine.” It’s only enough of a lie to seem true in a wise way, Catra hopes.

“What’s your name?”

“Catra.” And she shakes when she says it, and blames it on the cold.

“You’re a woman, aren’t you?”

“You could say.”

“And it’s nice, right? To know who you are, and like it. That’s something to want.”

“It’s nice to want anything. It’s a luxury. It’s nice to want at all, so feverishly, that you’d cry. I’d tell you to stay alive for it, but that doesn’t apply here.”

“You sound like you’re from far away.”

“It’s the accent.”

“No, I’m not sure.” She misses the joke. Catra wonders if this conversation is ever going to take her where she needs. She’s running out of advice.

“Look kid, I can’t explain this to you easily, but when you die here, you don’t just come back. You have to reckon with the reasons. That’s the catch.”

“And all the girls?”

“They’ve got it nailed. And so will you, soon, but this time I have to help.”

“Who sent you?”

“Heaven if I know.”

Catra takes her hand and runs, out of the bathroom and down a school corridor. The tannoy system is blaring something useless, and blood drips from the walls. At the far end, the one Catra is desperately looking away from, a schoolgirl with a knife in each hand looms lifelessly, her too-large mouth wide open and infested with shark teeth. The smile is stuck on. At once the tannoy changes as they burst through closed fire doors into a stairway, and what must be the schoolgirl’s voice, corrupted by impossible vocal cords and a gaping maw into something horrifying, comes echoing out.

“He’s a weak little shit. Weak pussy boy. I’ll eat him alive!”

The girl clings tighter to Catra’s hand and starts to sob again.

“This is only you saying these things. Please stop thinking.”

“She kept smiling as she said it! Like she didn’t know it was bad!”

They make their way in haste up the stairwell and out onto the first floor, where more corridors extend in every direction. At the end of each one, swaying in unison like a house of mirrors, is the same shark-toothed girl, her mouth now wide open. She dashes forward at impossible speed, and Catra barely makes it in front of the girl in her hand to take a wild swing at the schoolgirl with her unsheathed claws. There’s a weapon in her pocket but she wants to keep it for when she needs it. The swing is ill-timed and instinctive, but it catches the schoolgirl down the side of her face. Three incisions drip metallic crimson onto the marble floor.

“Why is it so terrible? I was born to die just like a man.”

The girl seems oddly resolute when faced with such peril, but Catra can hear the dark note in her words. There’s a horror there that transcends one such definition of death. She guesses, very quickly and before the girls in the kaleidoscope corridors have started moving forward, that a culture like this would separate death and oblivion, whereas for nearly everyone those are much the same. There’s agony, and then there’s infinity. It’s easy to make reasonable the torture of even an impermanent death, but every time someone has tried to define infinity they’ve only gotten further away, even here. Even as the schoolgirls rush forwards at once, even as they lead Catra in a spiral, as she blocks the biting and kicking and screaming with whatever limbs she has. This is getting bad.

But like an angel from some bastard’s idea of heaven, blonde hair and the visual echo of two piercing blue eyes come tumbling down from a doorway buried in the mess of corridors and take most of the schoolgirls down at a moment’s notice.

“For fuck’s sake.”

Catra turns to see the girl next to her has let go of her hand, and is staring upwards with an impenetrable expression.

“Who is she?”

“You don’t want to know.”

They both look back in sync to find the not-so-mysterious figure panting hard in the centre of a spiral of corpses. Or at least, they look pretty dead.

“Fixed that for you- there,” they say with pride and a dark look, their voice echoing out down the hallways.

“You weren’t really supposed to be here,” Catra awkwardly half-shouts back, trying her best to project her voice over the reverberations of the many rooms.

“Was I not? Oops. You can’t hate it. You said you’d love to see me again.”

“I said I hoped we would see each other again. Hopes are fragile. They blow away.”

“I should have been more careful rushing past you then.” And Adora moves to run away, but stops to look down at the confused girl standing at Catra’s arm. “Oh, it’s you, isn’t it? You’re why we’re here.”

“I’m what?”

“The crying girl! Good find, Catra.”

Catra glares at the source of the patronising words. Those damned lips.

“Are you a Policeman?” the now-resolutely not crying girl asks, with some reluctance.

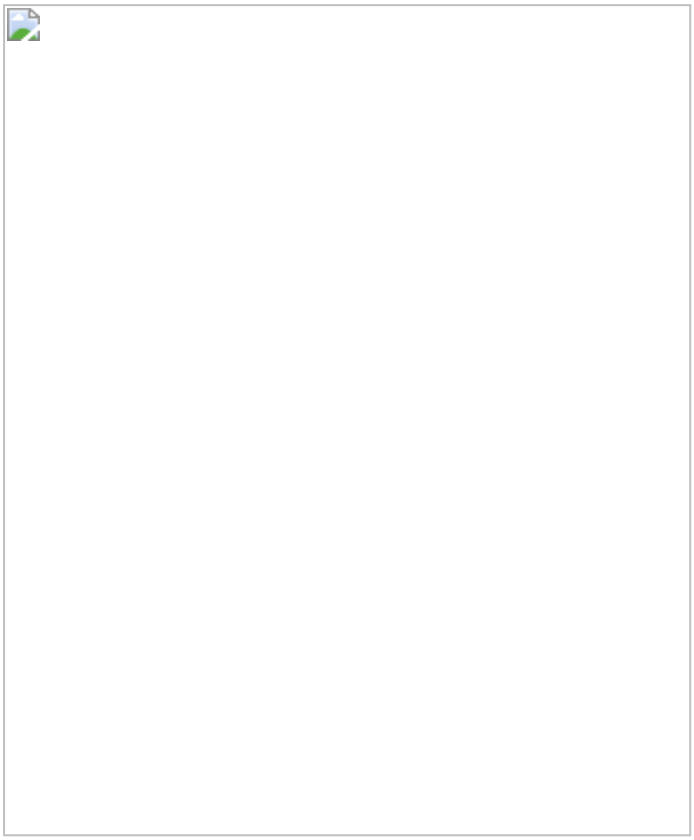
“Darling, I’m not even a man.”

“Oh. Sorry.”

“It’s okay. I’m here to save you, for real. Not whatever she’s doing.” Adora says it like she’s telling a child’s fairy tale, not fighting intergalactic war.

“But she’s been protecting me.”

“Not from all of them. Now come with me. We have somewhere to go.”



And the girl looks up at Catra, with more tears in her eyes, and mouths *sorry* , and walks away. Adora doesn’t turn her head when she next speaks, but they all know who the words are for.

“In a way, everyone tells the truth to you. You just have to get good at not seeing what they say, and instead seeing what they want. What she wants is chaos, and you know she means it, because she’ll only tell you if you ask the right questions. We’re going back to reality, but only if you want.”

“I want to go home.” The voice is small but determined. Catra watches on as the distance grows between her and them, unable to do a thing with the child so present, so vulnerable.

“Good boy.” And then they vanish.

In their wake is a letter. Just parchment and ink this time, a shadow curled around beige.

Now it’s my turn to be pissed.

I always forget to introduce myself politely in these letters. I get caught up in the heat of battle, my words fighting me fighting them, like some crazed schizo poet in the throes of an illness that no-one can be bothered to fix yet.

So that mission, huh? Crazy stuff. Wild. Crazy. Never found a world with built in death before. Probably never will again. So it’s a shame, really, that I had to play the bad guy, because there’s so much good to be done in a world with an unentrenched death drive. I wonder if they have a funny moral system. I bet you were wondering about their gods. And I know I said we shouldn’t play the bad guy or the good guy, but that was for each other. No point in not hamming it up for the crowd.

Wait, I was gonna be angry. I guess weird and manipulative is more my strong suit.

So, fuck you, I guess. To be so easy, so sweet, so tender, when before I’ve seen looks of yours that could tease at the fabric shell of whatever constitutes my soul and reveal all of its boundaries to be nothing but a fantasy in your eyes. An evil look, then, but that was just sad. What went wrong? Did she, or he, soften you up? You know her eyes said he was a he. You have to look for the eyes. Look at mine. They speak to you.

Fuck you, Catra, you inconsistent hunter. I need to predict you, to develop ideological frameworks, to call you a name that means something real. It’s how we do things. I guess it’s what I deserve

for fraternising with the enemy - everything is on everyone else's terms.

Goodnight, demon girl. I hope the malleable geography of inhuman dreams treats you with clarity, but no kindness.

Best wishes,

Adora

FUCK OFF GET FREE WE POUR LIGHT ON EVERYTHING WE SEE/CAN'T RUN AWAY

Chapter Summary

PART 1 - FUCK OFF GET FREE WE POUR LIGHT ON EVERYTHING WE SEE
Adora explains herself. Catra takes initiative.
PART 2 - CAN'T RUN AWAY
Catra gets herself caught. Adora gloats.

Looming.

Seeping.

A great gangly thing with four legs and four arms.

"Hello, Adora. I'm the Mainlander. We'll only meet this once, so let's keep it brief-

She awakens in a cold sweat, her brain stuck on the nasty words of her own letter sent. Words have the power to echo back, she realises, and pushes down the anxiety with an audible sigh. For all the strength she purports to Catra in their brief talks and the longer time spent in the almost-presence of each other, she's weak at her beckon call. Then again, there was that time in the desert. Adora got spooked, whether by the end of the world or a scary girl in a leather jacket with claws hewn from a neutron star. But it's not worth resting on the darker lining of her success on the immortal planet. She has more places to be, and more time to rest.

"Mission report. Confirmed code 3ABAT-2409. Please detail all anticipated eventualities first, then all unanticipated eventualities second, then any issues with the Hegelian diametric meter, then any issues with other equipment."

Adora stares into the machine in the corner of her room. It grows out from behind the wall, from the leering belly of the castle, a gargled mass of moonstone and mile-high thorns that weaves its verdant way through the purple corridors and dormitories.

“Confirmed code 3ABAT-2409. Received data packet 64, acquired boy/girl, took through portal for research as according to imperative subsection 42.1-4. And there was… she was there. No issues with Hegelian diametric meter. No issues with other equipment.”

“Who is “she”?”

The deadened voice of the machine is cutting. Brightmoon insists the machines have no spirit, but Adora sometimes worries otherwise.

“Horde agent recorded as C4-STRNR. Encountered multiple times on previous missions.”

“Enemy agent C4-STRNR is documented and her presence has already been noted by supervisors. Information erased from report. Thank you for serving the throne.” And then it switches off, like a bastard.

“Well, they know something I don’t,” Adora mutters to herself. The soulless words of the now-blank box in her room still haunt its limited periphery as Adora returns to the warm embrace of her bed. The form she takes on Brightmoon land is weak and fragile, a measure introduced by the supervisors a long time ago both as a control mechanism and a perverse display of strength. If no-one can even find us, then why must we prepare to fight, went the rallying cry of propaganda. It even made The Horde believe that those in the mythical castle had become fat and lazy, and so for a while the war calmed down. But all Adora has ever known is turmoil on the battlefield. The gentle rush of those deeming themselves worthy of death is itself a haunting from the past - her warfare is brutal and without will. When Brightmoon taught Nietzsche in the great scholarly halls to children who could not

care less about the state of a world they never knew, the mantra would go, "He who has will has power, and he who has power, can impose will." What bullshit. Adora knows that the greatest power known to even the first man only construes mindlessness. People do not gain willpower with a gun; they gain the horror of a puppeteer. The limbs of her victims do their dance, blissfully free of an owned control. The puppets march on, unafraid. Catra would tell her to shut up.

Adora spends three days in her bed, letting the nihilism seep either inwards or outwards, she isn't sure. Her supervisors spot the illness early on and try to alleviate the descent with some kind of medicine that Adora doesn't recognise, but she has a bad reaction and so two of those days are spent sweating and in and out of convulsions. The medicine supposedly doesn't discriminate between mind and body, spirit and spirit, but maybe it needs to, Adora thinks. She can't muster the strength to leave bed and complain when she has that exact thought. After the third day, she forgot about it. Her brain is instead full with the echoing words of the machine that looms large in the corner. And her own words too - why *did* she leave the boy/girl? Why did she take him somewhere at all? Adora knows the practical reason, that part is clear, but in all the pretension towards Catra, the guiding hand towards the boy, she never had worked out whether or not there was one of her own reasons, and Adora is fond of inventing those if she is that way inclined by the mission. They never contradict, always adhere, always spelling out the imperative. She had to get the boy out of the girl, right? To separate the mixture. To keep order ticking along on the earth of recycled souls. She sits on the edge of her bed, her mind racing, and tries desperately to impose her will. Her values on the sorry state of a girl in a boy in a girl. What's not right doesn't come easy, not without wrongs. And Adora doesn't know how to be treated. If the girl had said no, she would have failed, but would she have been insulted? Is the beckon call of a monster with a body made of recycled gore so repulsive compared to her? And why was she being so nice?

The last thought isn't directed at anyone. Adora has left all people behind. She collapses back onto her bed sideways, dreading the

knowledge that she *will* get up again. She wills and wills, until her body rises, and she can change into a more agreeable form to run away towards her sticking place, her recurring destiny.

A non-space tunnel takes her in a silent roar towards a choking Earth. Gutted by machines, inhaling smog, the surface teeming with the machined efficiency of corporate organisation. Where the desert world was shaken by nothing more than erosion of rock and the heat of the sun, where the suicide world was covered in a dream-like, rotting ecstasy, this industrial world is painfully man-made. It's not even war here; it's far more apocalyptic. Wars are the act of perceiving violence in order, so they end, Adora has come to learn. Civilisation croaks quietly onwards even if you stop believing in it, and more often than not, it chokes out life in just the fashion that is presented before her, high up in space. The tunnel is calculated to get her onto the surface smoothly and silently, but Adora deliberately pushes herself faster downwards, to try make a dent in the hum of machinery. She hates this sticky hell.

"Look how long her hair is. It's beautiful." The voice of a foreign dignitary, dressed in stiff, grim-free cotton, watching her walk into the room. Adora watches her too, and frowns. She looks so bold. It's strange to see, after the cowering and the helpless spite of last time. When there's no child in her arms, she turns sour. Adora turns fully to face Catra, having accepted her fate, and the two share a vivid moment of eye contact. Suddenly, Adora's suit feels all hot and sticky.

Catra's been staring at her the whole evening. At first, those mismatched eyes had a provocateur's glimmer, a flash of the distant and the deadly, but they've warmed as dignitaries have droned on with their speeches and food has been passed around in a conveyor belt of well-dressed waiters towards fattened oligarchs who know exactly how rare what they are eating is. Catra's kept staring, and Adora almost wants to stare back and find out what happens when they break. So she almost does. She keeps watching, watching the wrong movie play out, tracing the lines in those distant eyes, forgetting her own mission. She

blended in so well to the dance of yellow and blue that she forgot to be a spy.

Adora is a communalist. It's an echo of what the people here call "old-world" Marxism but given the historical nature of industrialised apocalypse worlds, everyone has started to cling to the olden times. The businessmen in their monocles, the galleries full of the ornate and the rigorous and the triumphant, and nothing that has the right kind of gruesome, ugly details to be found, just a paled reflection in a mansion hallway. A single violin player accompanies a pianist in the corner of the large, pseudo-Victorian room where the gathering is being held. There's a missing member of the ensemble. She remarks this observation to the particular dignitary she's clung onto, a loudmouthed representative of a gas power firm.

"Is that a piano trio without the cellist? Awfully misleading."

She lays the accent on thick but the representative is drunk and doesn't seem to care. He believes, not without reason, that she is the daughter of some oil oligarch, who's most eye-catching quality is the decision to wear a suit and tie, not the rebel ties. Of course, she's really neither Communalist nor heir to an oligarch's throne, but different lies superseed where needed.

"I suppose it is, s- madam. Are you by any chance a purveyor of the fine arts?"

"Oh, you know, I dabble. Nothing else worthwhile to do these days."

"It's bloody well true." He pauses to burp. "But I always think we take for granted those times, when the dirty and grimy shut up."

"They'll get loud again."

"And you would know them so well, hm?"

"I have my instincts." Adora's tone is perhaps too biting, and if the representative weren't hammering back wildly expensive

substitute wine he might have recoiled, but she has no chance to bring him back to agreeable anyway. Catra steps in from nowhere and finally fixates her eyes away from Adora, glaring down the red-faced man. Red from drink, but Adora knows Catra will appreciate the reaction.

“Don’t like your tone. Fuck off.”

“Yes, ma’am.” Catra turns back to Adora, her staring all the more uncomfortable up close.

“Well, you seem- more in control.” Adora’s voice is carefully measured. This is where the danger kicks in.

“It’s because you hate it here. Makes me want to… own the place.”

“And rule it just to keep me out?”

“Something like that. I’m trying at least.”

“Well you’ve got him under your thumb.” Adora gestures back towards the drunk representative, now shuffling through the crowd. Catra nearly laughs.

“Better well had do. He can ruin a good dinner.”

“I was getting there.”

“Ohh, that makes sense. You don’t want to be here, do you?”

“How’d you get that? I thought you were gonna just guess the obvious role. And yes, I have to.”

“So we’re fighting today, I guess.”

“If you like.”

“Maybe not. Let’s say we didn’t see each other, call it a draw.”

“And not a child in sight.” Adora smirks at Catra’s still piercing eyes. The silence between them hangs even amidst the bustling turmoil of the rich and famous.

“I’ll see you soon. Take this.” Catra hands Adora a hand-sealed piece of paper. She pockets it, goes about her business undisturbed except for the fluffy, split-eyed ghost who keeps inhabiting the corners of her eyes, and takes it out to examine only when she returns to the small shack reserved for mercenary forces of the Communalist resistance, safe in the knowledge she gets to vanish soon.

The letter is blank except for one ornate sentence:

HOLD ME UP TO THE LIGHT...

Adora does as she’s told, and returns home with knowledge fizzing about her brain, the words barely surviving the cleansing journey through non-space.

...and it feels like a thing I can’t remember.

Let’s cut to the chase. I did a little digging after our last sojourn, trying to figure out the meaning of two things. You might be interested to know what I found.

Firstly: the phrase “Look how long her hair is. It’s beautiful.” The girl said it, but to you, and it felt like it wasn’t from her. So I took to the archives in the Horde’s lighthouse (don’t bother looking - I know you guys hate that black hole) and found a record from long ago. A story by a man called Phillip Mainlander. In his strange world of sisters at war and endless pastel landscapes, the greatest horror is the end of an online forum. The phrase is the last thing anyone says before it is technologically bombed to oblivion, and Phillip’s sisters lose contact with the world. Weird.

Secondly: the phrase you used in your own letter. “Malleable geography”. Not to insult your literary talents, but it sounded like you stole it. Which is admirable, but I needed to know where from. And if it was on purpose, then I misread you, because to

me it seems subconscious. So I did more digging, and I found the hidden works of a composer who went by the name of Homeiswhere, and I found a song about the externalities of existence and the fluidity of passion as locked to the immediate present. It was a slapper, as they say. Did they play that as a lullaby? What a weird choice. Brightmoon loves conformity, but perhaps the best way to teach that was to teach everyone the difference itself. Oedipalised by a friendly master. Or maybe I'm getting it all wrong.

Mentioning Brightmoon probably puts me on bad terms. Are you guys like Rothko's Basilisk, a bioinformatic hazard looming in the fabric of my words? It's taken an awfully long time to find me regardless. Those things are like religion; belief that you are going to die correctly.

I'll see you when I see you. Remember; we try not to fight anymore. At least, I don't want to. I don't want to do anything to you. It makes it less scary.

Adios

From Catra.

She's fucking had it this time. A mission into the heart of Brightmoon? Catra doesn't know the inner workings of the Horde consciousness - even her own twisted inner machinations couldn't possibly approach the kind of being that would dare inject a black hole of pure violent consumption into the heart of existence, but goddamn it! This isn't even cruel so much as it is stupid. Everyone knows that Brightmoon, that golden-purple castle in the sky, that great monument of waterfalls to the depths of the universe and to the heights of eternity, can't just be walked into. As opposed to the usual delineation of defense mechanisms used by places of secrecy and importance, Brightmoon fucks with your head and hands all at once. The walls make you believe they are taller than the mountains on distant planets where tectonic plates the size of a star collide and shake the fabric of reality, the bricks make you

feel weak and feeble against the densest substance known to man, and the fact is, no one has ever worked out whether they actually are. Whether this palace for gods, currently owned by tyrants in gold, can even exist. Her tiny space vessel has taken her without issue to the entrance, but now she's here, the spectacle is overwhelming. All she has in her hands is the note, that until recently had been kept safe in her reassembly quarters back in The Horde. The note that reads her real name, her real opponent, her real… something. Its data hacked, its core elements stripped for worth into a bio-key that could access the heart of a great empire, Catra suddenly feels a sense of betrayal. Whether she is looking behind or in front of her is a different matter entirely.

Out of the note, a key. She presses the worn paper to the golden brick work at the base of the castle and suddenly, it all begins to melt. The paper shreds itself and the wall drips and peels away to create a person-sized hole into which Catra's form neatly fits. She's decked out for the occasion; a sleek, form-fitted suit, jet black with red streaks down the starkly flat chest piece, her tail neatly encased in a sheer sort of plastic. When in the castle, her suit takes on the colours of her surroundings, a sort of mural piece to her back and a soft yellow light filling the room. The melted part of the wall recongeales, its sensors too frazzled to alert the rest of the castle of an intrusion. She's halfway down the hallway, her steps deftly quiet on the marble floor, when a door opens at blinding speed and she's pulled through into total darkness, tiny lights on her suit lining only just clicking on in time.

"Catra, what the *fuck* are you doing here? Your letter, the-"

"Adora? I could say the same," Catra whispers with enough shock and anger to get her point across, gesturing at the formless void of a room around them.

"They know you're coming."

"They?"

“Just listen. We've been planning for your arrival ever since you set off. I managed to sneak away but I didn’t know if I was gonna find you. They don’t know exactly where you are in the castle, so you have time, you can-”

“You’re seriously helping me right now. What the fuck? I assumed you would relish this chance!”

“Not like this! We fight on the battlefield because we have to, or so I thought. Did you come here to kill me, or something?”

“Not that I’d tell you, but no. Espionage mission: check the suit.” Adora does, and Catra is way too switched on to not notice the greed in her staring.

“Well, um, you need to leave. You’ll be captured and either decomposed again and again for eternity, forced to reassemble in whatever torture machines we have buried deep in the castle basement, or just killed. For real, killed. That’s not how this is meant to go.”

“I can’t just *leave* ! There’s vital information somewhere in this castle that’ll trigger my being returned to home base, and unless you can find the whereabouts of Ligotti’s last document yourself, I’m stuck here.”

“Do The Horde seriously run missions like that?”

“Efficiency, darling. Anyway, help me, or fuck off, okay? I get this isn’t our battle, and I won’t fight you, but I need to know what’s gonna happen here,” Catra says as she turns to leave, knowing what the answer will be.

“Well, I can’t help you in person, but I can point you in the right direction.”

“You can *what* ? You’re allowed to-”

“Shut up. The data containment facility is down through the palace room doors. Take the elevator to the lowest floor. The

castle is quiet now so between that and your camouflage you should be safe."

"Thank you, Adora."

"What?"

"I said, thank you, idiot. Now go away." And she does. Like a winter's breath, she's soon one with the crisp castle air, leaving Catra to make her way towards the facility.

Adora was right, it turns out. The castle is dead quiet, the elevator standing still, doors open towards the vast central palace room. It's a monolithic thing; a giant throne, chrome pillars and those familiar waterfalls to infinity circle Catra as she steps forward to take the slow ride down, her camouflage holding, her stance weightless.

At the bottom, the darkness is just the same as in the mysterious room with Adora, save for row upon row of bright blue crystalline cubes sketching out the vast size of this underfloor section. Catra moves to browse this prismarine array, scanning each cube with as much speed as care. The darkness beats down on her back, her slender frame pumping slightly with each heartbeat. Then all the lights switch on.

Suddenly, the room is a colossal, blinding white, the humming ambience of the data cubes dwarfed by an array of industrial-looking spotlights. Catra turns in mute shock to find two spear wielding guards, shimmering with plasma energy, in fighting positions next to the elevator. They advance slowly in her direction, and Catra prepares herself for what will be, given her bad deal with equipment and wetware, a bloody struggle. She moves quickly behind a tall casing unit of the cubes, unsure how the guards can even spot her given the camouflage. The blue glow flickers on her chest and arms as she prays quietly to be unseen, hoping to find the right cube and vanish into the light. The *light* . Catra looks up and spots a decoding pattern in the vivid shine of the warehouse spotlights, and looks back down at

herself to see the edges of her suit frayed and visible. Then, the two guards turn the corner and Catra only just flicks up her guarded lower arms in time to block their combined blow. She spins out of the combat deftly and clambers up on top of a nearby casing structure, dashing towards the elevator with a knife in hand. She needs distance between them to formulate a plan, and there's no way they will take those spears into a confined space. But as she comes to the end of her room length dash, she finds only a vast hole where the elevator should be, and looking tentatively upwards, sees the damn thing descending slowly back down.

Catra glances back towards the oncoming guards, knowing that what is most likely coming down is way, way worse than anything they can give her. So she turns back and away, aiming to eliminate the immediate threat as quickly as possible. She takes a looping route around their approach, scything through a kneecap or two as she ducks under an oncoming blow the moment all three bodies meet. No scream, just two drops of blood and a nasty cracks. The knife in her left hand glows with anticipation. Her next meeting of blade and flesh is much more poetic, much more on her terms, as she dances back towards the incapacitated guard and cuts straight down their chest with one swift hand movement, painting in red on their soon-to-be corpse. The second guard doubles back and meets her with two swift thrusts of the spear, its glowing hot tip searing the sides of Catra's chest. As she moves to retort, the guard simply turns and runs away, and Catra, confused and suspicious, doesn't even follow. Her decision is proven right when a voice comes from the end of the room, reverberating slightly.

"Hey, Catra."

"Oh, fuck you."

The two begin to battle, as they have done before, but with every strike and parry, every elegant circumvention of a fatal blow, Catra starts to sense that something is *off* . Adora is defensive, reticent, not quite the cold killer Catra had known. Her blows, delivered

with a familiar sword, are shortened and stifled, always considerate of Catra's response a second too far ahead of time.

"You're slow today, darling."

Adora takes a shorter, sharper breath than Catra has ever heard, and whispers her response.

"Trust me."

Their fight suddenly doubles in intensity as Adora moves onto the offensive. Surely she knows Catra can't win like this? And what kind of trust is forming here? Blow after blow comes streaming down on Catra, her body weaving in and out of wrecked data cube shelving and, for a vivid moment, nearly tasting the tiled floor as Adora moves to take her out from underneath. Her suit is stiff and torn, her forehead layered with sweat and creases. She pants to herself for what should be a moment too long. The move has left a hole. Without thinking Catra dashes forwards, a small voice screaming incoherent as the knife takes hold, and draws blood from deep, deep gashes down Adora's contorted back. She freezes for a second, her body all tense and strained, her face serene. Then she collapses, a familiar looking note in hand. Catra stares brokenly at the quickly fading corpse.

The note reads two things. First, on the side left out and open in Adora's cold hand:

GET OUT. USE MY SPIRIT. IT'S GOING FAR AWAY.

And second, on the back, a full letter. Catra can't stop to read it now. She knows what Adora means. Her essence will trace a path away from the castle, and maybe Catra can ride the flow of energy, or at least the path of communications it has to initialize, back to her craft. All she has to do is get off the ride, so to speak, before she's landed back in whatever secondary facility Adora's body is reconvening at, presumably due to the security breach that Catra might just have caused. Oops. She takes one last look

at the corpse, mostly ether now, and lets her own form fall away.

Hard pass through the neurological stratosphere. Catra's components reconvene across space and time. The tunnel paints itself on a universal canvas, a giant maw open wide.

She's taking a breath when she realises *she's taking a breath* . Which means, through some miracle, things seem to be okay. Well, on a rather relative scale of okay, which Catra supposes is all she can afford to think about. It takes her senses a minute or two to re-emerge untethered by the cosmic mess of pure essence, so when it happens, the white-knuckle grip of her left hand on seemingly nothing catches her attention. She relaxes, letting tension escape her body in a slow breath, and finds a battered note half-furled in her palm. It's a miracle it made it through the interstellar-travel-via-physical-decomposition part of her little journey, let alone the brutal fight. Or, more accurately, it took an immense amount of willpower, so much so that in Catra's current tired state, the note seems to be disintegrating in her hand. She turns the paper over and commits Adora's last, but not final, words to her memory, tucking them deep, deep down where The Horde doesn't dare look. They look pretty next to their siblings in a display case; Catra makes a note to visit soon for spring-cleaning.

Hey.

Sorry about that.

It wasn't meant to go that way.

First things first, that wasn't the castle. Hell, the castle might not even be a castle *. It's just agent shorthand, you guys' fault for taking it all literally. But yeah, we have really good augmentation simulators and after intelligence discovered you had plans to get to our centre we couldn't resist a trap. The location in spacetime was given to you by a fraud, by the way. Don't buy his information again.*

Secondly, yes, I threw our fight. No, it doesn't count as a win for you. I was getting you out alive. I was lying mostly, but the part about being decomposed forever if they, or we I guess, caught you, was true. You probably already guessed, though. You're smart like that.

You know, I'm starting to like you. Is that dangerous? Should I be afraid? Affection and fear, a match made in heaven. Ha. Heaven. Did you ever come across those who believed in heaven? It made them so unafraid. They'd preach to the skies of a thousand deadly days with the conviction of a madman in love. This isn't all! they'd cry. You're not alone! I hate to be the bearer of bad news, so I kill those I find. Let them find out for themselves. Let oblivion be their teacher, let them fear the void.

In the end, their fear was the same as mine. We all want to live. We're all gonna die. Can you separate thought from desire?

You're probably laughing right now. What a pretentious bitch, she says. Murder's fun, she says. What do your lips say? What did your eyes say to me? Catra, I want you to know how scared I am, and how alive I was in all of those scared, vivid moments, and I want to see you again very soon.

Oh, and I almost forgot. You mentioned the Mainlander in your last letter. I didn't know you, or they knew. Maybe they didn't know to know what to know, or something. It doesn't matter now.

Bring back the hunky demon look next time. Skinny and short doesn't suit you.

Adora.

BLUE SKIED AN' CLEAR/SNOW GLOBES

Chapter Summary

PART 1- BLUE SKIED AN' CLEAR
Adora gets artistic. Catra gets flirty.
PART 2 - SNOW GLOBES
Catra learns to sing. Adora learns to love.

“Agent, I shouldn’t have to tell you what death *means* .”

“No, I know. It’s difficult, and protocol says so or everyone would just go around living forever,” Adora lets out with a pronounced drawl.

“Yes, and that would be bad for appearance. Nearly every race we’ve ever seen has been mortal - it would scare them half to death.”

Adora stays quiet, only slowly becoming conscious of how odd that is, or how apprehensive her supervisor looks.

“You’re tired, surely. Or- uhhh, *fuck* , Adora, tell me what’s wrong. Pronto.”

“I don’t get tired.”

“I mean, existentially.”

“How can I get existential? Even the world with suicidal girls had fear! They were *afraid to die* ! Like it’s scary at all.”

“Adora, they were still human. They get scared.”

“Your fault for making me look like a human and think like something else. I get confused.”

“It’s protocol, *agent* . You’re actually starting to piss me off. Sort whatever this is out, or next time you have to deal with human

beings I just know it's gonna go nasty."

"They have a god for all that fear!" yells Adora, still hung up on the human mind to the exasperation of their supervisor.

"Huh- no, the gods are all different for them, that's simple-"

"Bullshit! All the same. Every one of them is about fear in some way."

"Every Finland we've ever observed has had a god of rocks. Explain that one with your oh-so-clever thesis."

"Projection. Imagining the rocks are alive enough to need a god."

"That's fucking stupid. Go away."

Adora storms back through castle hallways, a slight smirk on her face, until she reaches her quarters. The memory of Catra's single tear, her slight body in battle, her… there's something new. So new it hasn't been old long enough to have newness yet. Something from beyond. Her room starts to spin, this casualwear body barely equipped for temporal fuckery. The bed and mirror lose their anchoring, and before long Adora is on the floor, the memory of a Catra who has not yet become real searing into her head. A hand reaching out from up above. Screaming. A great toxic expanse, a dress, a voice in distress. Two faces. Green eyes.

Fires burn in autumn skies. Adora can't make out the stars for all the screaming.

And she's back. Cold floor, a pink empty room. Hers. Walls, four of them. Waterfalls and starry ceilings.

There's a note on her door, flashing pink on an iron surface.

NEW MISSION. STRAND 37-B4. NO PRESENT DANGER. DRESS CASUAL.

No-danger missions are a rarity nowadays, and given her track record, Adora never gets them anyway. She stores the unfamiliar NPD code in her immediate memory and moves to get ready, stopping in front of her rearrangement chamber to plan her strategy. She'll be briefed on the specifics of the Strand when she's gotten changed, but that's not the concern. The concern is that Catra will almost certainly be there; whether The Horde has a track on Brightmoon or vice versa Adora does not know, but she is certain that the frequency of their finding each other cannot be an accident. So she ignores the DC mission tag and, stepping into the chamber, adopts the same body as before. Strong, alert, most likely completely unsuited for the task at hand. Catra demands her fullest attention, and maybe she'll like the muscles.

"It's easy, frankly. You're visiting an art museum, where a new exhibition is being put on by some socially conscious dickwad of this Strand. It's gonna stir some controversy, which we need to mitigate at all costs, so you need to weasel all the reporters into taking a pleasant view of the work. Is that clear?" Adora nods and turns towards the transporter. The Strand ID is already plugged in for her. "Your identity is a personal friend of the artist. They won't be appearing so you can get away with a few casual lies. And uh, Adora?"

"What."

"The get-up. Really?"

"What, you've got a thing against buff girls?" And with that, she leaves.

Adora's advisor heads quietly out of the deployment room when she sees Adora's molecules have disassembled fully, and makes her way to that cold, empty room of pillars. She waits in the half light for a moment, still and saddened.

"Catching signals that sound in the dark," she whispers as she looks over Adora's bed. The covers are messy, her bedside table

littered with souvenirs and rubbish. “You sweet, sweet two headed girl.”

Next to the bed is an essence recharge port, basic equipment for any agent who needs their lifeforce reinvigorated after a mission. The advisor reaches down, a vial of something strange and lifeless in her left hand, and drains the port of most of its power. She replaces the empty space with the deathly substance and walks slowly away, leaving the room to be cold and alone.

What a shitfest. Cold, white walls, a rumbling murmur of faux appreciation, the nagging sense of sucked-out joy and needless rambling and pestering of what few great artworks are standing proud amidst cheap minimalism and gaudy excess. Plastic bottles on the floor and uncomfy benches. Awkward silences filled with garish visuals. A kind of synesthetic mess. Adora meanders depressedly through halls arranged by some sadist to be as difficult to navigate as possible, conscious that somewhere she is going to stumble across a wavering tail and a deadly grin. The day unfolds slowly, the unveiling of whoever’s new best ever piece set to take place at 6pm. Just 3 hours. Catra is nowhere to be seen. Adora is still uncomfortable with that name. It doesn’t sit nicely in her head; it moves about and gets everywhere. Do The Horde equip their agents with special brain worms, or is Adora just infatuated? She doesn’t know. Her brain is getting all fuggy in the white halls that loop round into each other, spewing social debris like some kind of postmodern ouroboros for the pretentious and faux-lonely.

She lets the last remaining hour tick over by admiring a strange piece at the furthest point of the western corridor. It’s a fuzzy thing - Adora guesses the obfuscated brush strokes were enhanced by some kind of digital trickery. So she’s looking at a weird marriage, the meeting point of not-quite-uncanny technological interference and the moment where human hands lose their grip on the real. A voice echoes from next to her.

“Weird, isn’t it. Two worlds that don’t belong. I mean, I always thought it was cliche, to put two obviously disconnected things in

tandem. Marriages always break up, probably. What do you think, *Princess* ?"

And there's the insistence. The passion, the rage, a little fire in the most flammable room. Adora turns as slow as her twisting heart will let her, and eyes Catra with varying emotions that don't seem to parse well on the other end. Catra is, like her, dressed not at all for the occasion; she's lean and sinewy, the tendons in her neck visible despite the collared suit jacket.

"Now *that's* weird. I'm just your rival in time and space; chill *out* ." Catra lets the last word drag from her mouth and deftly licks it away with a tongue that is just barely too long. Adora will notice. She'll notice the sway in her hips as Catra leaves as slow as she can manage, or the short hair and the tall, looming demeanour. Painting in contradictions; she makes a note to hit herself after the mission is said and done for being so obvious.

The unveiling comes, and it is a non-event. Adora weasels her way into the crowd, and into the ears of journalists and public figures with practiced diplomacy. Gentle social commentary slips into casual conversation, kinds of fake radicalism that settle the hearts and minds of the culturally rich without threatening anything real. Allusions to nasty politicians that everyone will agree is nasty; Adora scores laughter with surface level jokes and empty platitudes time and time again; everyone plays their part perfectly. When the artwork is revealed, shock certainly fills the room, but Adora notices most of all the quizzical looks on the faces of a targeted few, the reviews with words like "bold" and "uncompromising" already half formed in their heads. She nearly retches and backs away from the scene before the artwork, a mutilated sculpture of a pig with the words "YOUR POLICE STATE" screaming out in black ink, can get to her any more. It's not affecting, just empty and stupid. And it's worse for the fact that such an insignificant conclusion may be the point.

At the edge of the crowd, still uneasy from the artwork, a voice appears in Adora's ear.

“The painting was called Blue Skied and Clear.”

Nothing more is said, the slight breathing and close contact of the plosive sound enough to draw out a trail towards the voice. Adora follows willingly, a hidden pit of fear unfurling in her stomach. That’s a new sensation.

And there are very quietly, all the people leaving a white room to enter bright lives, and every one of them passes Adora on her way across the hall with reason and purpose and the need to be somewhere.

Catra’s face is tight and quizzical, gesturing to nowhere. Adora struggles to find some way to break the space most commonly filled with a sword or a snide remark.

“So no fighting today, I guess.” Adora’s voice is tight and stiff.

“Apparently not.”

The silence rests again, only for a pleasant moment this time.

“Catra, don’t just stand there. I mean, you found me here. You spoke up, *you whispered in my fucking ear* while I was trying to do my job.”

“You were hiding in a corner. And besides, you weren’t looking for me? Really?”

“Hmph. Fair game. You’re not even gonna interfere with my work?”

“No. I got out here with what you’d call a white lie-”

“I’d call it a protocol breach.”

“Shut up. Anyway, I lied to get here. I mean, I am keeping an eye on you, but this mission was never gonna work out for me. Your job was too easy, and violence wasn’t really an option given the setting and importance.”

“You’re a traitor to your own agency.” Adora phrases it like she’s making some great accusation, but her tone is light.

“Good. If they can push me around like a chess piece, I’ll off myself. I guess I just lied when I said about why this gallery isn’t ash in the sky then. Maybe I have *really good* manners!”

“Don’t make me thank you. No explosions is like a baseline acceptable for good conversation.”

“Okay literal pyromaniac girl. I bet you loved blowing up that award show. Ruined my outfit as well. I *loved* that dress.”

“You did not!” Adora catches herself smiling along with the false indignation. It’s another sensation to add to her growing list of worries.

“I so did. Almost as much as I love those muscles.” The flirting is barefaced and Adora’s mouth goes a little dry. Catra has a sly smirk on, almost as if she knows that Adora isn’t supposed to get all flustered at something like that, as if she knows she totally has.

“Safety protocol. Just in case you- or someone, tried something funny.”

“Where did shouty smiley girl go? I miss her already.”

“You know what you did.” Adora hopes the slight irony mixed in with the edge of her words will come off right. Luckily, Catra rewards her with a grin, an honest one, the tips of her fanged teeth glinting in the white ambient lighting. Then the silence falls again, to Adora’s protest. “So, catty catty Catra, do you often find yourself disobeying your supervisor’s protocol for a hot girl on the other side of reality?”

“You’re the second this week actually.”

“Wow. Premiere ladies man, I guess.”

“Don’t worry, I only write *you* the letters.” Catra points with a jagged claw at Adora’s chest, a red-faced smirk painted on.

“Well, I must say I’m honoured. The handwriting could use some work but hey, no one’s perfect.”

“Don’t give me the empty aphorism treatment. C’mon, I want feedback. What would be better?”

“Hmmm. Well, there’s always the stars.” Adora’s voice is breathier and more considerate in this moment. She knows what she means, and she’s scared to mean it.

“I’m not gonna-”

“Write me a message in the stars, one time. I’ll know it’s you.”

“That’s-”

“Ooh! Or, you could sing me a song, like either something you wrote or maybe steal one, I probably couldn’t tell.”

Catra smiles weakly once more, then turns and runs. She’s out of the gallery front door in seconds, and away to home, storming through the vast array of Strands, barely corporeal.

Adora doesn’t dare pursue her. It’s not her path to take, nor her soul to comfort. Around the kinds of shaky ground that any of their interactions must, by very nature, take place upon, Adora is all too reticent to go chasing a girl into the cosmos over bad flirting. Maybe Catra wants to be pursued, to struggle formlessly about the stars and the flickering remnants of a thousand breaking points in time itself, to be a damsel in existential distress. But there is no room for error in her mission. The halls of the gallery are sparse, a muddier white than before, the lights all going out. She walks the long path home, the slow route from Earth to Jupiter, meeting a throughway portal to home round the back, so to speak.

And it is there she finds newer beauty than beauty has ever been.

Written in the torment and violence of a gas giant, the cowardly words of an almost-lover. There is a title in big bold letters that screams out:

DEAR APHORISMS.

Adora keeps those words proudly at the entry point of her mind, and stores the rest away for safekeeping as she returns home, tortured and alive.

Don't pull that shit with me, lover girl.

The fucking stars? I mean, there's making a joke too soon, and then there's that *.*

I won't hold it against you, actually. What would be the point in it? We don't need grudges. They take time, and we have very little, or all of it to waste. But you have got to cool it. Yes, I've played it off before, but The Horde is the Horde. I don't know what to explain to you other than what you know or have experienced yourself, but it's bad, Adora. They'll get in my head if we stray too close to the line. It's a thankless miracle they don't monitor planetary surfaces.

I'll keep you and I distracted then. God, what did we even first talk about in these letters? It feels like it's been talking about talking about talking about how much you're attracted to me or something. I think back then I just wanted someone to piss off. Heh, back then. It's not been that long at all.

This isn't the last time we'll see each other, Adora. Something sticks us together, something big and menacing. Tell me if it scares you, and I'll promise to do the same.

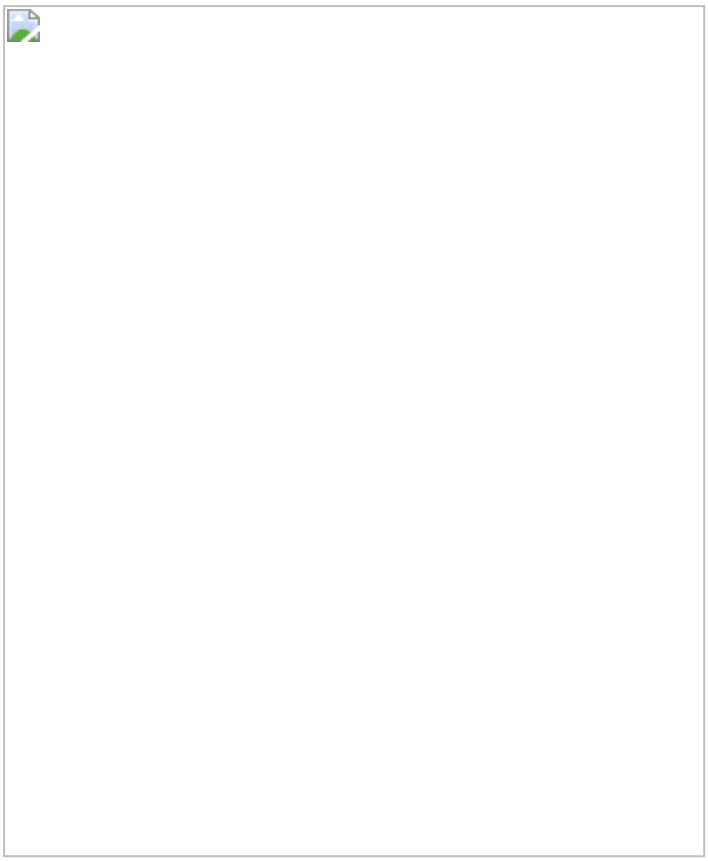
Best wishes,

Catra

"God of weather

Even knows

Snow globes don’t shake on their own!”



Guitars ring out past her voice. The musicians are locked in a trance, motoring through their parts in some kind of static ritual, the pedals adjusted to perfection, each shimmer of the lap steel dancing with the driving melody beneath. There’s a direction to the whole thing, as if even during the endless meandering splatter of drums the piece, the stark movement of guitar and bass and the gentle caress of her voice on the microphone picks out a location in the great emptiness of something that neither the performers nor audience recognise. It’s warm and stuffy in the basement. Catra looks around while the band takes the song out, and in the sweaty crowd, blues eyes drag her right to attention.

Catra’s room isn’t really a room. That would imply four walls, ceiling and floor, a sentimental splattering of belongings and memories, a bed, the perception of linear time. You know, reality. Catra’s room isn’t in reality. It simply *is* , without premonitions,

conditions or perception to mitigate the purity of its being. It goes for as far as it must, exists when it can, and the toilet empties out into pure nothing. Which is to say, without a funnel Catra's room would be full of shit. She supposes that the Hegelian mechanics of The Horde are some kind of big practical joke, and as she lays in a state of conscious stupor, the idea of a pure comedy being the deciding factor in what amounts to her life wedges itself further into her mind. It's been some time, at least to her, since she saw the face that never leaves her, and The Horde is only getting more and more bold. She can feel the whole place whirring at high speed even when she is confined to her quarters. Everything smells of crisis, her equipment catches the scent of death if she's not around, and rumour has it that the black hole is swelling. That great pustulent scar. And of course the rumours are propagating; Catra recounts without much fondness the numerous times that an entity based on the principles of pure chaos has been strangled by its own propensity for gossip. Drama is truly universal. Something arrived yesterday in the docking bay; Catra took her own, unofficial path to have a look, and saw only two crinkled pieces of parchment and a glass cage be exchanged between a faceless figure and Shadow Weaver, who like usual was to be found at the centre of some inevitably awful scheme. Catra heard her mutter as she walked away down a dimly lit corridor, "the quiet plan is dead." Catra thinks she's heard it said before. But like with all memories, all residents in a linear flow of time, it's best not to touch it too much. Just wait.

She waits for the "go" sign. It's been worryingly long; Hordak knows she's one of the best agents, but it seems on this occasion that her superior is choosing to run his political games instead of securing results. He knows Catra gets too much credit. She's just worried that her chance at the highest echelons will be impeded too soon by selfishness. Nothing else.

" *THIS MISSION WILL BE SOLO. NO IMPEDANCE. BRIGHTMOON FORCES HAVE NO KNOWLEDGE OF OUR OPERATION. PROCEED WITH 0 CAUTION.* "

Catra doesn’t know whether to be thankful or nervous. 0 caution missions are usually her chance to slack off, not that an intertemporal war awards much casual time. Well, technically.. Catra doesn’t let her brain finish the joke. She’s worried. If everything is going as it seems to her in The Horde, then why such a danger-free mission? It’s out of order.

She’s overthinking.

She’s strapping in for the long ride.

She’s free.

Divebombing through the Strands, Catra catches flashes of awful visions. A sky devoid of stars, a bright face with blonde hair cascading down, frigid castles and forests covered in blood. Interference in the temporal non-space between codified arrangements of space is nothing new, but these sights are clear and sudden. The actual inner parts of the world are murky space; whatever is making its way into Catra’s head is from somewhere concrete.

Without warning, the sights abate and she’s locked on. Some iteration of some planet Earth, by their measure in the calendar year 2019. She’s phased into a dark back alley, clothed in what looks like a goth get up. The mission prompt was as brief as The Horde ever is: act as a stand in lead vocalist because the original guy killed himself, don’t fuck up, make sure to find some weird kid after the gig because he goes on to lead the spirit of some post-collapse revolution, inspire the weird kid, go home, sleep for a short eternity. In theory, Catra should love this mission; events surrounding the collapse of a whole human race have always held a particular interest for her, particularly the emerging states and societies, the so-called neo-leviathans, and their accompanying cultures. She’s a historian at heart, though those in The Horde designed for praise have always said she had an artist’s touch. An artist’s touch in the field of brutal, uncompromising murder, she might add. The alleyway flashes with the light of a passing car and drags her away from her thoughts.

Backstage, the band preps her on what she already knows. This body is built for singing, her trained vocal cords resonating with precision as she warms up. The six or so band members around her tune their instruments in silence, clearly perturbed by the unfamiliar presence in what must have been a fairly personal space. She's gotten good at that unsettling effect; maybe it's the heritage of chaos, or just being a practiced shit-starter, but something about Catra sets people on edge. Even Adora seemed… she seemed *like she isn't fucking here* . Denial is a slippery slope, she knows. She doesn't do slippery slopes, or denial, or paradoxes. Slightly on edge, she walks out on stage with a rehearsed smile familiar not only to this body, and machines her way through a tensely charged set clearly wrought with emotion for those band members still grieving. They hammer away at a particularly noisy improv piece as Catra pretends to feel something, pretends to find her solace in a harmony travelling beyond her soul towards oblivion. She's moving on stage, static in her heart, letting out a final scream as the piece moves to climax. They have one more song in their set.

"God of weather

Even knows

Snow globes don't shake on their own!"

Catra curses the sky. The audience thinks she's revelling in the glory. The band due to play next waits in the wings, and all Catra wants to do is run again.

"You scared me."

"But you couldn't hear me!"

"Your presence is pretty noticeable."

"I'd like to think I just caught your eye after all that screaming."

Adora is alone, in front of her, outside the venue. Catra's encounter with the kid was uneventful, a rushed attempt at

inspiration, the seeds of leadership blooming in his mind. Phenomenology isn't her strong suit - manipulation is never fun when you miss the results, but at least it's a job done. Now she needs to get some real manipulating done. Adora needs to give her some *fucking answers* .

Catra's skin is cold and her instincts are begging her to go inside. She's let her ears out into their natural cat-like state, and they are going painfully numb in the night air, but she refuses to let Adora go without answers.

"So, what exactly are you doing here?" Catra asks with a poorly intentioned smirk.

"It's uh- well, I'm not gonna tell you. Mission business."

"Come on, you're a talkative girl. Give me the goods. Brightmoon'll never know."

"I mean, they- uh, they literally will. Mind reading and all that. It's-"

"You're bullshitting. I know you are."

"I don't have *tells* , Catra. I'm not human."

"Never said you did. I'm perceptive, is all."

"Perceptive of what?" Adora seems to think she's got the upper hand with that absolute non-zinger. She raises an eyebrow and Catra suppresses a giggle. Since when does she giggle?

"You're stupid."

"I'm a genius. And I'm hot. Why haven't you fallen for me yet?" Oh, so she wants to play.

"I'm not as easy as you, babe."

Adora lunges in for a kiss. She crosses the night air between them at a speed that even Catra is shocked by, pressing their lips together with a lonely passion. Catra doesn't allow her brain to set on fire like she so wants it to, doesn't let herself succumb to desire. Desire moves human consciousness, and Catra is very much not human. But by god, she's alive. Her hands slide under Adora's leather jacket, pulling them together with just enough urgency. Adora's own touch on Catra's body is electric, her lips warm and wet, and when they finally part something big and scary lingers in the night. "Kissing me to avoid answering simple questions is a really stupid game," Catra says, her voice coloured with sharp breathing.

"I didn't do it right. Can I try again?"

"Now, *that's* just cheating." Adora's smile is an almost telling response. She knows she's a good fucking kisser, and whether she just wants another go or Catra's questions really got to her is anyone's guess. It's harder to see inside another agent's head.

Her ears are twitching as she waits for Adora to say something, anything to drag her out of shock. "Adora?" Maybe the other agent is as zoned out as she just was.

"Huh? Oh, you're- yeah, you're supposed to like, not just go silent after a kiss."

"Time travelling murderer gets flustered by a kiss *she initiated* . Without asking, I might add."

"Did you mind?"

"Not really. I'm down for one time flings."

"Hm. Yeah."

"So I'll assume you came just to get some lip action, violating your superiors and every single principle that you've ever followed, and there's nothing more to it, right?"

“Right-”

“Don’t give me that.”

“What? You asked!”

“You know what I was asking, *Adora* .” Catra almost spits out her name, almost wanting it to mean something worse.

“I can’t- I’m sorry, Catra. Even if I could tell you, and I can’t, we’re stuck here. This is way too conspicuous. Someone’s gonna find us!”

“The Horde doesn’t track me on-”

“You fucking think so? I’m here. They are tracking us both. We need to go.”

“Adora, you read my letter. You fucking promised. Come on-" Adora slides a knife into Catra’s chest. She’s not prepared for a fight - The Horde wouldn’t let her get out of the door battle-ready given the mission circumstances, so the deep wound drops her to the floor without resistance. Adora vanishes past her prostrate body into the night.

Catra is struck vividly with the knowledge of two things as her spirit fades back towards The Horde. Firstly, that Adora doesn’t pull the same knife trick on herself and travel back the easy way, but instead runs far enough to escape the surreal, snapshot-like vision Catra is just barely able to muster given her rather incapacitated state. And secondly, that the patterns of blood and gore in her body and their dance around the knife edge have laid out another letter. She stores the patterns deep in her thoughts, ready to mull over when this strange situation has at least resolved. God, she’s gonna have to explain her ass off.

The vague darkness of The Horde welcomes her uneasily home, her form coalescing in its default state of cat-adjacent humanoid. She’s dragged away into some dingy, miserable backroom where a faceless supervisor examines her once, before spitting her out in

her room. No questions asked. Huh. She should ask, just to tie up loose ends.

“Hey, Hordak.”

“Good day, Catra.” His voice is rough and metallic, the disapproving tone cutting through her personal communicator like knives. Good timing.

“So, say I were to have encountered some unexpected obstacles on my most recent mission, obstacles I wasn’t at all prepared for, how would I go about getting your ass fired for it?”

“All occurances are planned for.”

“That is evidently bullshit.”

“ *Evidently bullshit* to you or not, it is perfectly true.”

“I can read, *fucker* . I got told there was gonna be no intrusion. I got killed.”

“We know. All occurrences are planned for, including occurrences that may result from what mission prep you are given. Goodbye.”

The screen blinks and goes black. Catra curses violently and launches it across the room. It flies for an eternity and lands ten metres from where she stands, shaking with anger, now staring at a cracked screen. Fucking typical.

Catra doesn’t want to read the letter. She’s angry at Adora, angry about the taste of her lips, angry for a quiet mission gone to fucking waste. Adora shouldn’t keep showing up, because Catra knows firsthand that the universe is extremely big and last time she checked Adora wasn’t. She sits in her bed and waits for desire to poke its head round the corner, trailing on the coattails of fury like it always does. Her strange fear of whatever Adora *is* does not exist in the absence of their combined terror, but despite the abundance of it all. Everything comes to her in the end.

Dear dearly departed,

Yadda yadda, didn't want to have to kill you. I imagine you're at the very least annoyed, though you'd call it pissed off. You call everything different, like you're looking at me with different eyes. It's a shame, because I paint you into so many things, and you don't notice. I painted you into your own blood.

This is my apology letter, though it's not my first letter with an apology. It'll be long, and I hope dearly you stick with it, but if not, please burn everything you know of me. I can't stick around like an unfinished story in your head.

So I'm sorry. I told you to write my name in the stars, then I kissed you on a mission that you had hoped would be quiet and stable, then I killed you. Nasty series of events, and one I wouldn't wish on my worst enemy. Ironically, I did wish for this all to happen, but not right now. I told you to write my name in the fucking stars, and of course I forgot how space echoes like your fucking tomb, and the stars are burning all the while. I'd call it a Freudian slip (do you guys have Freud? He's a right laugh) but that would be offloading responsibility to a version of myself you can't shout at, which feels mean. I told you to write my name in the stars, forgetting my own words, not biting my tongue. I get myself in situations that I cannot escape, and this time I only have the sun to beg for my forgiveness.

But isn't it odd?

Isn't it bizarre that a word could mean everything? That even when we were stupid and blind at the dawn of creation, infinity was in our grasp?

So I'm sorry. I made the mistake of forgetting the ginormitude of our situation, for not getting afraid, even when you were so clear about your own fear. And bravo, by the way. I never give away my fears. Not to you, yet.

So I'm sorry. But these apologies are for tomorrow, so let's not dwell on today. We both know the deal, and most importantly we know what we don't know. We're at war, and something seems to be moving faster than it ever has before. I'm not keen on sticking around when everything goes tits up, and I doubt you are, either. The Horde will get tyrannical, Brightmoon always normalises the crisis until the universe bends in fear at the lifting of the belt, and you hate all of it, I'm sure. This isn't an invitation to run off into the sunset, more like a reservation for a hotel room that may not yet exist. One with a balcony and a good view to match, a king size bed and room service. One where you never noticed the cleaning gets done but you always come back to soft sheets. I've booked my spot. It'll be the place to stay in your case, too. I'll see you there.

Hugs and unwanted kisses abound,

Adora.

THE MOON/SUN

Chapter Summary

PART 1 - THE MOON
Adora tries out fur.
PART 2- SUN
Catra runs away.

Adora awakens in her chamber to the gentle flashing light of a new mission and the gentle premonition that something is fucked. Her dreams, which she isn't supposed to have, were coloured by the visions, which she isn't supposed to see, and she'll have to take this mission at the risk of putting herself in danger in the field. The details wash over her brain when she leans over to stop the light flashing. This is going to be difficult.

But she knows what to do. Something has to be going wrong.

It's imperative that she plays this one right. There's a perfectly reasonable explanation out there for the visions, but she's sure she won't find it with her supervisor, nor can she access any of the other proper channels. These are aberrant mistakes in something far more fundamental, in perception that can only be tampered with by a select few, and can only be tampered with on purpose. She runs to her room, picks up two spare planetary re-entry kits she keeps in secret, and only just barely notices the green vial of liquid plugged in at her beside. Well, that must be it, but it's too late now, she realises in a vivid second. All she needs is to get out on a mission, and-

Fires burn in autumn skies. A piano in a field on fire. The bombs drop on the taught surface of a single word.

Fuck.

Catra is at risk.

There's no way to tell her. She'll leave. She'll be brought back. They'll hurt each other. She can only keep the illusion safe.

Thankfully, she knows her fairytales. Myths for children are the most fundamental; before it is practical to explain to a child the illusion of the world, what is explained is the illusion of each other. Fairytales are their own kind of pure reason, and as a furious student of the things that make sentient creatures tick, Adora has to know them all. She can teach all the children that belong to a thousand different suns, and like any good director, she can act when needed.

The mission tag is thankfully simple, an isolated venture deep into the 16th century, the fulfillment role of a story that must be told. Earth gets its fair share of stories - as one of the few planets capable of sustaining persistent life, it attracts attention from agents from all corners of the universe, and all that wild power bleeding into the corners of ordinary human vision leads to tall tales. Some say that James Joyce was driven mad by agents of The Horde swarming him, others insist he was just mad. The universe talks of its war, even when the battlefield is at everyone’s doorstep. Adora stores the tag somewhere unimportant in her brain, and, making sure to clean the detritus from past missions, sets out on her way, leaving the castle hastily.

Preparations pass by in a haze. Adora takes on the required accent, attire, mannerisms and the story to be told in a blind stupor, barely registering the reality of her situation. And it is only when she leaves her supervisor’s room that reality finds her again. Three sharp flashes in her vision, and luckily she has just made it inside her quarters when her whole head becomes shaken with vivid imagery. She can feel her bones rotting inside her still-living limbs, the cracking and grunting echoing around her room as she shrinks and shakes. The walls get painted with fire upon fire. Burning in autumn skies. The woods. The trees, golden and silver. The ashen trees. The violent hacking and shivering of someone on the precipice of being and non-being finding the sickly, disgusting, sad end of their own body to not quite suffice. A resounding voice from the centre of the sun. The light of the moon. Blood rivers.

Adora gets up and dusts herself off. Her bones feel weak and her head feels full. It's time to go.

Ironically, she's ended up in another castle. This one is old fashioned brick and mortar, the dingy grey walls and creeping moss up the outside a refreshing sign of life being let free. She waits outside the gate, her humble possessions (all totally fake, of course) in tow. She's rehearsed the lines. She knows the story.

"Good morning, kind sirs of the castle of Fearnhamme. I am but a lowly serf, and I beg of you that I take refuge at this castle given the despicable treatment I found under my past lordship." The accent is practiced, her trimmed hair and flat chest giving away nothing about her being anything other than an unlucky farmboy.

"Oh! Hello. I'm Perfuma, and it's fine to meet you, boy. I'm the lady of the castle, and, well, we sure could use some more hands around here!" The lady looks Adora up and down, her eyes quizzical but empathetic. Adora could not care less. The mission has already been scouted. The story has to take place. "Come on out of the cold. We'll get you something sorted."

Later in the day, when the cold that had clutched at her bones in the day has closed in for good on the hilly terrain surrounding the castle and made a fireplace into a haven, Adora is watching a flame dance in some common room. Her eyes are glazed, desperately hunting for patterns in the fire, waiting for the endless moment where the heat ends and air begins to impart some great wisdom on her tired brain. Those moments never come, as the time painted by the flame extends outwards. She is pulled from her reverie by gentle footsteps.

"I hope your accommodations are suitable. We don't have much, since I'm the only land-owner here, and the other women of the castle dwindle in number each day."

"They are leaving you alone?"

"I hope so." A silence returns. Adora focuses on the flame again.

“Boy, what is your name?”

“Alex.”

“And you came here in refuge from your lord?”

“You’re awfully assertive for a lonely lady.” Her words have spite behind them, but she does not know Lady Perfuma well enough to mean it.

“It happens when you don’t have a man to cling to.”

“I don’t know what that would be like.”

“Of course not, of course not. You cannot even pity me. You’re a pretty boy, though. I’m sure the woman of wherever you hail from treat you well.”

“One did.”

“Was she beautiful?”

“All the time.” Perfuma goes silent. She stares at Adora’s face coloured by a flickering half-light, and opens her pursed lips once as if to speak. “Is he dead?”

“Is who?”

“Your lord.”

“I suppose so. You should know the details, I guess, given that you may take up stay here.” Perfuma does not actually offer the details. She keeps pursing her lips tighter.

“How can you own all this?”

“Well, though I wouldn’t expect a serf to understand, there was a protracted debate between me and those with power in the business of land and property as to whether I might keep this abode to myself, given that I am as you can see a lonely and morbid woman, with-”

“No, no. Surely it’s lonely? All that space to walk in, and nothing to walk towards.”

“I have my library and my girls. We can wheel away the days with reading.”

“But your lord is gone!” She doesn’t look as hurt as Adora might expect. This conversation is pushing her luck.

“He didn’t love me, he owned me. And now I own the site of his majesty. You should go to rest.”

“I don’t mean to be rough with my words. It’s been a long few days. I needed someone to rile up.”

“Sleep wards off the worst of the day, I find.”

“At home I kept trying to rest, but what haunts you is up here. You cannot sleep your brain away, my lady.”

“So be it. Make some kind of peace in the night, while you have the chance.”

Adora stands up slowly and makes her way to her modest quarters on the far side of the castle. Her bed is rough, the blankets scratchy, but her sleep is less disturbed than she fears. All that sticks is the feeling of being watched, the spectre of two divergent stars and asteroid belt claws. It’s familiar, and it makes her smile as her sleepy eyes welcome the break of dawn.

In the daytime, she is tasked with menial handiwork; farming and cleaning, excising the grime and rot from the castle and its grounds. Her thoroughly inhuman body makes light work of the fields and the mossy stains, but at lunch time she puts on a disaffected, sweaty show. Her conversation is always light and often pleasant, as she holds back the worst of the bubbling spite found in that murky evening conversation. She lets her hands carry her through the afternoon, and comes in from the fields in the half-light.

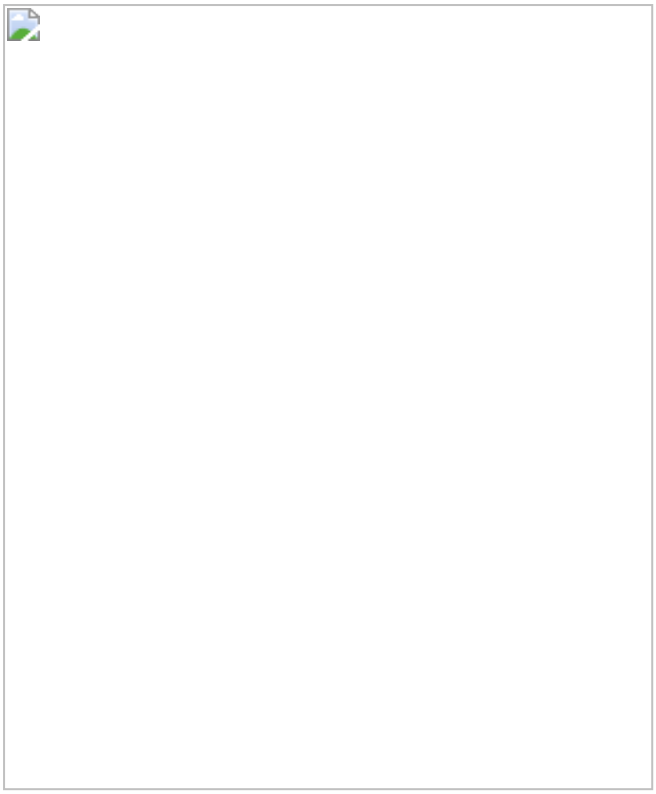
One of the ladies of the castle is turned away from her when she comes into the castle through the back door, her short cut hair glistening with sweat. They all stand in something like a static barrier, rough linen for her to dry off with in hand, but only one face is hidden. Adora peers out the window, an open sky stretching far, a small village scattering the hills to the south. There's a moment for her there, where the sky sings to the trees and they shout back, where the colours are the breath of gods, in an awful mess of gold and green that touches the sweaty shoulders of an agent in time with the love of a mother, the eyes of a forgotten world. She looks breathlessly back and eyes the four ladies with suspicion, but takes the linen and a small leather container of water with breathless thanks. It’s a surreal and still scene; the light sketching on the wooden floors, the line of blushing women, Adora’s tending to scratches and dabbing herself dry the only movement in the room apart from the shaking of two clawed hands. The ladies leave her be in a different formation that they entered, the clawed hands leading the pack away. Adora catches a glint and her brow furrows deeply. Good nail care isn’t the answer. This half-light shines on the right things.

Adora’s been counting the sunsets. There’s no clocks, so the days form around work, and past dinner is a void. She sits out on the castle wall and watches the sun travel down, her meal going cold beside her. She’s done it twice before; once one of the ladies awkwardly joined her and spoke very little. When she had heard Adora’s breathy voice, likely higher than the men of the day, she had perked up and the conversation began to pass back and forth, but they both knew why they were there, and Adora knew the outcome. Tonight, the third night that the sun has passed her vacant stare and her cold meal, she’s waiting. The moon should be up tonight. She doesn’t talk as it rises, but silently she feels powerful, her chest full. She feels her size, floating in the same space over molten rock, her soft skin turning coarse. Adora clambers down from the wall and travels out into the forest. She makes sure to leave a trail.

The forest is painted red. A blood moon.

She can smell her round the corner. In fact, Adora can smell a lot *more* right now, the essence of the trees seeping in. This forest is deathly familiar, reeking of death, her newly wetted nose the central territory of a kingdom of horrors gone awry. Someone special has followed her into the guts of life.

Amidst a sea of towering red and brown and deep night sky black, Adora hears her own bones cracking and shifting. Each shot of pain up her spine and down every nerve is a reminder of her duty, the bulging eyes and prickling skin, a tailbone creaking outwards, reformation of the face itself. She scratches at the stretched remains of her clothes. Nothing is screaming yet but under the light of the moon she suddenly feels beyond powerful, assuring her place as a creature of the night between two molten rocks. Fur rips across her torso and the tensed muscles in her legs, her stance dropping, her mind on fire. As she takes tentative glances in between explosions of pain she notices just how far she's gone and just how far she has to go. The transformation is long and arduous, impossible without the strength of mind she has to have, but even so the pain flashes are accompanied by short bursts of another time, another green world of pianos filled with flames and crying girls in a minefield. A world where her skin is soft and her mind is alive with the stories she always knew, and then-



"Adora!"

Her ears, now pointed, furry and impossibly sensitive, cannot be lying. That voice is so husky and desperate.

"I don't know what the fuck is happening to you, but you have got some explaining to do!"

All she can do is growl. It starts low and ends as a visceral feeling, translated by new vocal chords into a glorious howl.

"Oh. Right." Catra's voice echoes amongst the trees, the colour and shape dancing in the air around Adora's twitching ears. She approaches wherever Catra's voice was in an awkward all fours stance, her strange biology stranding her somewhere between bipedal and using her extraordinarily muscular arms for walking.

" *Wow* . You are one extremely buff werewolf."

When Adora finds Catra's slender form in the dark, peering out from behind a cluster of spindly trees, she sets about shaping her growls and grunts into something more verbal. The first attempts

are a series of strange half howls and are followed mostly by involuntary whining, but with Catra looking amusedly on this strange scene Adora finds the determination and eventually the technique. Her new voice is awfully rough and deep, a matriarchal rumble from deep within her chest, but Catra can hear her clearly.

"Hey, Catra. I'm sorry again."

Adora drags her into a tight, fluffy embrace, Catra’s blushing face pressed just beneath the curvature of Adora's breasts. "You're naked."

"How am I supposed to put on any clothes like this?"

"You could try not hugging me instead."

"You love it." Catra hears those words deeply, lets them rumble through her shivering body, and suitably convinced Adora isn't going to stab her again, lets her natural form take hold.

"I brought the full look this time. I don't trust you, wolf girl."

"Whatever you say, cat girl." With those words, Catra shoots up nearly one meter in height and suddenly recovers all her missing muscle. The transformation is so sudden that her head slams into Adora's right breast and knocks her backwards, and only when she recalibrates from the sudden rejection does she notice how incredible Catra looks in the bloody light. Her tail, pointed ears and muscular frame are like slender, intense mirrors of Adora's own body, the deep brown fur and torn dress a neat contrast with Adora's own blonde fur and the tatters of clothing still clinging to parts of her frame. Adora is pretty sure she can't blush, thanks to her snout and all the fluff, but nevertheless she's sure Catra knows how starstruck she is.

"Admiring the view?"

"So are you."

Silence takes hold. Too many tensions ride the air; Adora wants desperately to move closer again, but the impulse that drove their earlier embrace has vanished for its place to be filled by worry and guilt. It eats at her heart.

"So, about being sorry. I think I need to explain again. This is just another example of the stabbing incident, or, whatever you'd call it, but basically, I'm-"

"You're stuck?"

"Oh. Oh! Yeah. Maybe."

"You looked pissed at the castle, and I know you're similar enough to me to want free will of some kind. Plus you basically said it in your letter."

"I guess so. The castle was whatever I was angry at coming out. I have to tell a story, and I have to kill you if I see you, and I keep seeing what I have to tell next."

"You're seeing the future?" There's little shock in Catra's voice, but plenty of worry.

"In fits and starts. There's a story here, and whether I know it or not is… it's fuzzy."

"You're the big, bad wolf, right? You're here to kill me." Catra moves closer to Adora. Her form looms large in the light of the moon, but Adora knows that Catra is unafraid.

"I know. I'm sorry."

"And what is it that makes you trapped, Adora?"

"The reality of my fucking situation, Catra! What do you want me to do here? I have to get out!" Adora spits out those words with the knowledge of her past echoing around her brain, a thousand atomised slices of time desperately searching to be re-ordered.

“I don’t think it’s your reality. Your reality is locked up in that head of yours and I can just about see how much else it wants. Uninhibit the flow of your desire, darling.”

Adora sighs, lets a moment of calm take hold of her body, and looks at Catra with love and malice, deathly still under the gaze of the moon.

“We’re gonna have to run.”

Catra has been stuck here for weeks. All the newness is getting old. You’ve seen one castle, you’ve seen them all; she much prefers them after the long torrent of time, spotting all the ghost marks on walls and in worn down basements. That said, the onslaught of new missions isn’t treating her well either. She feels stuck between new and old, which is probably appropriate for someone of her profession, but also infuriating. That said, she realises, it's not like being stuck is new to her. She's been prowling the castle since her creation, always hearing voices in the walls, tuning out their chatter on bad days and cupping her hand to the wall, over her ear, twitching at the alien language echoing on the good days. Well, were there good days? It’s an awful shame, she thinks, to look back on an endless swathe of time and find very little joy in its surface. But there are bright, lavish days ahead. All she has to do is trust that Hordak was the right kind of right.

The day before she left, she found out some kind of horror.

"Catra, this next mission is particularly important. If you break away, or mess this up, the entire plan is compromised."

"Oh, good for me, I definitely know every detail of the plan and can adjust accordingly. You *dick* ."

"We've secured another document of Ligotti’s. As you know, a publicly available part of the plan was to seek information relating to him and add it to our database for analysis, and given that other agents have been a little less, shall I say, rebellious, we've

been successful. We know that there is an agent out there who is severely ill, and who is violating time itself."

"What the fuck was this Ligotti guy on about?"

"The information was encoded. It deals with puppets, most notably the horror of puppetry, but when run through the same algorithms we used to decode other known texts of his, the information became remarkably clear."

"But why encode it? Why not just say?"

"He was insane. But that is beside the point, Catra. Your job is to maintain tracking on our primary suspect. You must-"

"Oh. Fuck- maintain. Fuck."

"Is there something wrong?"

"You can't kill her. She's too strong."

"You'll be pleased to know we don't want to. We need to keep tabs. According to Ligotti, Brightmoon is oblivious."

"Sure."

"We have a track on her. You'll be given mission information as normal. You must not report this to other agents."

Catra leaves wordlessly, shaking in fear.

Whatever Adora is already scared her half to death, but this is new. This is cosmic, and Catra has to remind herself she certainly doesn't matter here. Whatever is happening to Adora could spell the end of things, not just one useless thing, spiralling out alone in the depths of the universe.

Before she leaves, Catra goes to visit the black hole. It's not so much mandatory as expected of agents, but she hates the visits anyway. The only person that lives nearby is an old hag named

Razz, her messy abode splattering the walls of a beyond-ancient lighthouse. Catra has never got on well with her. Razz is always out of sync with everything else, the black hole seeping into her brain forever. Catra walks inside the lighthouse to find the whole thing in a tizzy, cooking utensils upturned and chaotic hoarder's rubbish scattered over the floor. She ignores Razz, flailing about some ancient cooking contraption, and goes to the roof of the lighthouse, to look out, into the void. And what to say to something that only consumes? That eats away at the soul in the fabric of reality, that digests and digests like a great gluttonous beast produced by the same filthy desires that it chews on. It's terrifying, to speak at something that'll eat your words with no care, the sentences split to clauses to words to morphemes to the tiny grains of sound, the waves all twisted and distorted. Catra wants to scream at the great beacon beside her, and clamber up onto the brightly-lit peak, and scream louder, a cry so endless and useless it cannot even be eaten, not that the black hole cares. It eats what is indigestible, feeding on the absence of being fed. And this is how it wins, in the end: even nothing becomes something, and then all the universe is a great soup with the great gelatinous mass of un-things to show for itself, nor love or kindness or spirit. She screams so loud that Razz pokes her head round the door.

"Adora, dearie, lend me your young bones. I need to reach something."

"What did you call me?"

"Adora? Your name, silly! She's- you're saying hi, today, remember! It's your last day, or your first day, or- Razz always gets it messy!"

Catra sits in silence. Why does Razz know who Adora is? She's never mentioned her before. Clearly someone is going backwards in time, which only compounds Catra's earlier worries. This isn't just Hordak's conspiracies; if it's got to the madwomen like Razz, then it can only be true. They tend to treat reality like novelty.

She remembers it all in the castle as the sun goes down. Though the memory is ultimately unpleasant, she likes to map onto the great golden circle all the horrible images of that void as it descends. Because as much as it hurts, to imagine that there is a cycle, an ebb and flow, locked in the eternity of chaos is comforting. The sunset colours the castle walls in a sort of orange tinged crimson, the great pillars painted sharply across rigid stone by an ignorant gaze of evening light. Everything it touches turns to gold, which she supposes is a great curse for that great behemoth ball on fire, turning forever at the centre of things, at least for these tiny people. She's passing well as a maid, though the subservience disgusts her. Hordak probably played this one to his advantage as well, even now considering how he might train her to be weak, fragile, moldable.

Catra has seen Adora around the castle a few times now, panicking both at the muscles and short hair, and her furious demeanor. She's not sure whether the other maids are ignorant or just politely not mentioning it, but Adora looks primed to kill. Or like she's lost, at the behest of something else. It's best not to ponder it, and just play her part.

The first time Catra gets scared she's been spotted is in the back room, where Adora comes in from farming covered in sweat and dirt. Catra turns away, telling herself it's just to hide her blush. She can feel desperately every movement that Adora makes as the sticking and rustling of fabric echoes in a silent room. Perfuma sent the ladies down to be of assistance, clearly more concerned for the long, tireless hours that Adora works than out of any common courtesy, but all they can stomach to do is stand and watch. Catra can hear water dripping down her face, as vague images colour her deep stare out the door, her eyes catching on the wood and stone as she hears Adora grunt with pain. She's likely just tending to a scratch. Seconds later, she moves towards Catra only slightly, and in a rush of fear that drives her out the door. She doesn't even notice one of the girls gave her linen, nor that Adora keeps walking, just for a second, after Catra leaves, the ghost of her footsteps leading outwards to nothing.

The second time Catra gets scared isn't at all to do with Adora, she would insist. She's out in the courtyard, making menial talk with one of the ladies. Her name is Frosta, a younger girl, the daughter of a dead friend of Perfuma's. She's loud, and Catra can't bear to listen to her much longer.

"And then, there was this awful screaming, and then, it was just amazing- you've never seen anything like it!"

"Are you so sure?"

"I'm sure! This awful, snarling creature, yelling at the moon, picks her up and runs away into the darkness, dot, dot, dottt."

"Frosta, you can't pronounce the ellipsis. Besides, this isn't true. This is a perfectly normal place."

"Huh, how would you know?"

"I live here, you fool."

"Really, because everyone seems to remember you so well, but for me it is all… fuzzy. Something is weird about you."

Catra stares suspiciously at Frosta. Surely this strange girl couldn't have bypassed flawless Horde mechanisms in order to work out Catra wasn't born in this place, that she's simply an ill-meaning visitor? And does that mean something is badly wrong?

"Weird how?" Catra asks tentatively.

"As in- I cannot explain it. You don't belong."

"Well that's pretty rude of you."

"I pride myself on my bluntness and precise use of words."

"Anyway, go back to the werewolf story. Did you see anything more?"

"Oh, so you were interested! That was quick."

“I am having a little think. If the werewolf and your own strange fuzzy memory are connected, which given that they are the only strange things about this rather normal place would be reasonable, then perhaps there is more to that werewolf than just folklore.”

“Oh, but folklore is very real, Catra. We get told the stories as kids to keep us safe, and we remember them to stop us being afraid.”

“That’s awfully wise.”

“It’s what my mother said before she- you know. And no, I only saw the werewolf run off before I myself ran away.”

“I have to go. Thank you, Frosta.”

“Where to?”

“The forest.”

Catra moves swiftly in awkward get up through the trees. The moon is bright and bold, a gentle reminder as to what started her surprisingly useful conversation with the loud girl in the blue dress. She’s tracking a scent, letting her powerful nose guide her in the half-light, her now-slitted pupils blown wide to catch all of the moon’s glow. Silently, she feels all too powerful. If she’s not careful, her real form might slip out and ruin the story. Because this is almost definitely a story; the scent carries echoes in many different spaces, the realm of material reality and the realm of its echoes in the mental plane, the chemicals all imbued with some kind of torn spirit. She’s been lured out here, she knows, and she knows more that only one person would have the nous to lure her in this way, a way only she can follow. The footsteps are swallowed by the leaves. The trees are painted with the ash. The darkness lives in Catra’s head and spews out onto the page in a dizzy haze. And like a shot from the black, a grey, furry form emerges crying in agony out of the densest of the ashen wood.

“Adora!”

“Where are we even going?”

Adora is dragging Catra through the cosmos on a *whim* . It should be romantic, tender, beautiful, awe-inspiring, but all she can feel is fear, plus the confused smirk of Catra behind her, their barely-corporeal forms tumbling down the lines between forbidden Strands.

“I think I know a safe place, somehow. It’s somewhere in here.”

Adora doesn’t trust her extra memories, but given that accessing this particular one didn’t send vicious pain echoing through her body and that it seems entirely devoid of fire or death, she has no better option. The feeling is faint, a shadow from something that can never be mapped onto the Strand system, and she’s praying that her own willpower is strong enough to carve through the universe.

“When I was trying to get you to agree to running away I assumed you had more of a plan. You know, trapped? Usually you get trapped between two things, not one shitty thing and a gut feeling.”

The cosmos spirals around Catra’s words, in colours that aren’t real and in patterns without space to define them. It’s a nonspace, and it’s as safe as anything, but also desperately unstable.

“Actually, I spend most of my time trapped between a shitty thing and my own gut. It’s never that clear cut.”

As she finishes those words, the shadow suddenly triples in size, and she reaches out of the non-space spiral into reality, her hands pulling Catra’s like antennas to heaven. Suddenly, they are pressed together in the cold depths of space, tumbling towards a rocky, blue-green planet countless miles beyond.

“How are you so warm?”

“You might say I’m a… *space heater* .”

“Get off of me.”

Adora laughs quietly, her own joke taking her mind off the fear. Somehow, the vast expanse where they have surfaced seems devoid of a Horde or Brightmoon presence, as if the tracking has failed. It makes no sense, but the emptiness is a welcome respite from a busy, war-clogged universe. As they fall, Adora finds her most familiar form, letting the fur fade away. Catra grumbles when she feels Adora become smaller and more human in her arms, still unwilling to let them part as they slowly descend. Luckily, Adora made sure to bring the right equipment; their bodies can cope with the lack of oxygen and high altitude but not the impact, so the planetary re-entry kits mostly consist of high grade parachutes and safety fallbacks, which is bizarrely unlike Brightmoon to be so considerate. Adora unfurls both of the kits, tucked away in the pocket of her trousers now freed from medieval costume and werewolf fur, and hands one to Catra. They both pop out in unison as the atmosphere approaches, and immediately their rapid descent is slowed. Still, they leave a dent where they land.

(SO I'M GROWING OLD) ON MAGIC MOUNTAIN

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra find peace, and bombs.

Catra turns to face Adora after they brush themselves off, now disentangled, and looks quizzically at her and then the decidedly unassuming surroundings. It's a vivid green world, from here at least, but not nearly notable enough to warrant Adora's mad dash. "You said you knew where you were going. This doesn't feel like a known place."

"Trust me. That's the point."

Adora runs off into the distant forest and Catra follows begrudgingly. A distant world, a mysterious girl, the trees rustling in time. She supposes that if she had a particular favourite kind of fun, then this would be it. She's not even sure she knows what fun means. And as she tumbles over a hill and round towards the trees where Adora beckons, this place starts to make sense.

"Adora, it's singing!" she shouts over the gentle chorus of the forest.

"I know!" replies Adora, her grin just barely visible from a distance.

The melody is quiet and wordless, aimless even, but beautiful nonetheless. Catra reckons it's the space, the great plains, a world for the worlds themselves and someplace to dance among breath and openness and clean empty air. She spins to take it all in, and heads towards Adora, who has taken a seat by the forest edge. "Look, Catra. Food! For us!"

She's right. A picnic basket rests alone on the floor, the only other feature outside of the usual swathe of nature being a long upright

piano that Catra spots in the corner of her vision. “Okay, but that could be anyone’s.”

“After all the shit we’ve done, are you really going to take a moral stand on stealing free, unguarded food?”

“I’m putting my *dark past behind me* , Adora. I’m a *changed girl. ”*

“Oh, *of course. ”* Their voices drip with both sarcasm and a lighter edge. Neither wants to admit how bright they feel inside, now that an honest landscape can simply let them live, as opposed to the pulsing and shaking and searching of settings past. The plains feel alive with each other, a kind of poetic painting unknown, but beloved for them both. It’s terrifying.

“Come and sit with me.”

Adora has pulled out a blanket from God knows where and is laying sideways on the floor, taking hungry bites of whatever she can find in the picnic basket.

“For a second, yeah. I want to go see what that piano is about.”

“What that-” Adora swivels her head to see where Catra is staring off to. “Oh, that. Cool.” She returns without much apparent thought to her eating. “Do you like music, Catra?”

“That’s a pretty dull question for a first date.”

“It’s not a bad one though,” replies Adora sharply as Catra lays down slowly, clearly beyond being thrown off by the blatant flirting.

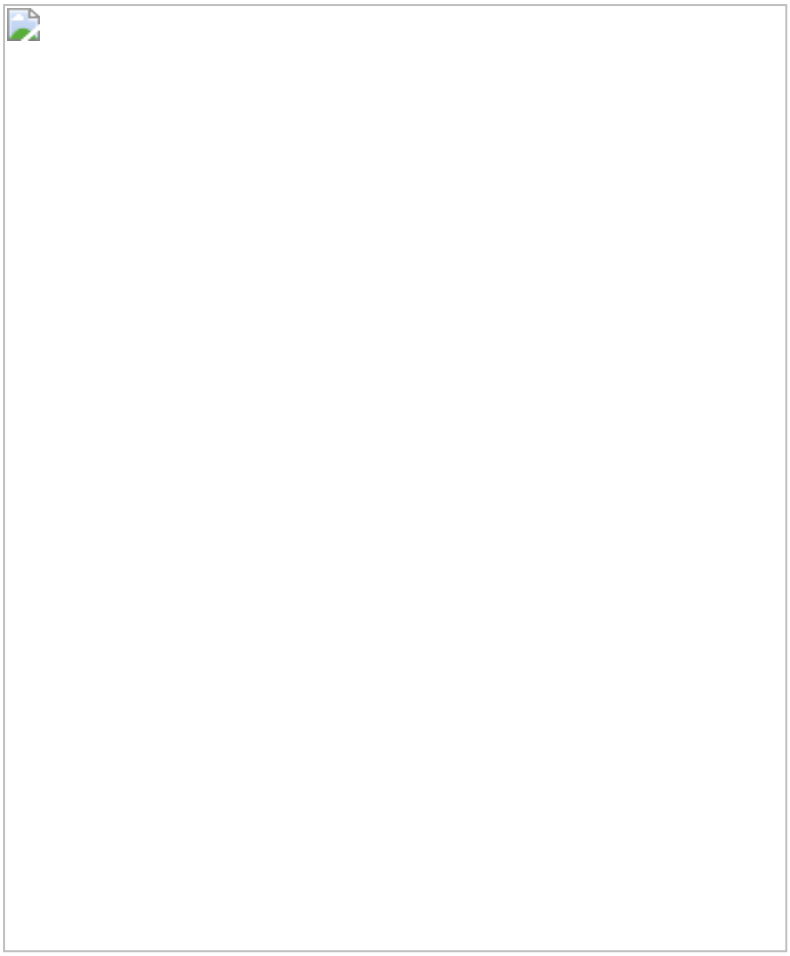
“Yes, I do. It reassures me. There’s no space, and you often forget about time. It just sort of forms around you, and you can feel however you must feel. Everything is beneath you with a good song.” Catra sinks into the comfort of her own ideas as she adopts a cat-like prostrate pose.

“Ooh, I love it.” Adora stops her nervous eating to pay closer attention to Catra. “Will you play me something over there then?”

“Just a second ago it sounded like you didn’t care.”

“Took me a second to figure you out.”

“Touche. I’ll make my way.” So after precious little time resting, she clambers upwards, and follows the spindly root edges of a number of bold and brave trees towards the piano in the centre of the open field. She has to remember something to play, or Adora will feel hard done by. But of course, she’s not bothered. That was never what performing was to Catra, not before she saw *her* face in the crowd and her soul dropped through the floor. It’s not worth the spiralling thoughts, so she orients herself around the creak of the piano bench as she pulls it back to sit. Her hands find the keys, and despite the nerves it’s an easy fit. And so she paints, in an array of verdant green, the trees to her back and the fields beyond, as each blade of grass seems to line wholly upwards and towards the sky in unison. The chords aren’t difficult, but they are bold strokes, captured in time by Catra’s deft touch. She doesn’t even know where she learned to play the piano, or why, but it’s the soul of the music that sticks. She slows with the gentle harmonies and speeds up to a mighty fury as the notes cascade downwards, assaulting the grass and the skyline. Her own endless spiral, to mark a lonely day together.



The piece ends on a mighty, incomprehensible chord, a tower of emotion that shakes in its place when Catra stands slowly from her seat. Silence falls as she returns to her spot, lounging just too close to Adora.

“That was pretty.”

“I sure hope so.” Catra gives her a deadly smirk. “But you’ll never hear me sing.”

“Fuck you.” Adora feels the silence again, but with a head of swirling conflict, she can’t let it stick comfortably forever. “Hey, Catra- do you think this was meant to be?”

“Steady on!”

“You know what I mean.”

“Well if you mean that we live in a deterministic universe full of suffering that has to occasionally compensate for the misery with picnics in the sun, then sure.”

"Uh, sure. But not that. Like your own choice, was it your plan? You're here now, and did you know all those footsteps ago that you'd be put here, and did you want it?

"Firstly, we aren't soulmates. I’m glad I’m not your soulmate. Being stuck inside someone’s head seems awful. I’m here, with myself, and do I love it? No, it takes time. If you knew someone else’s thoughts, you’d shit your ego out your pants while you weren’t paying attention. And second, my dear," Catra feels those words deftly in her mouth and grins when Adora goes red, "it isn't so much a case of splitting desire and journey as inferring desire as the product and creator of the path I've taken. I have no choice, but I have desire."

Adora goes quiet. She eats slowly and ponders, letting Catra’s near-rehearsed theories dance around her brain. "You're smart. Terrifyingly so."

"Don't say that. I never want to be. You're smart too."

"Not really. I just tell stories and paint well."

“But stories are magical! Stories are a teaching device, a lesson that unfolds. Every agent should learn with a tale. Even the lies tell the truth.”

“So, what stories did they tell you in The Horde?” Adora smirks gently, her expression quickly opening up to invite Catra to regale her with something magical. Catra catches Adora’s warm eyes and moves to take more food before responding.

“Nothing much. Lots of death. I mean, it was fine, we could take it. There’s no teleology to our lives there. We simply are, and then we aren’t, and everything in between is messy. So they explain the end first.”

“Huh. Sounds morbid.”

“So does everything if you phrase it right.” Catra’s tone is nonchalant, almost dismissive of someone who isn’t there. “Did they tell you any stories?”

“All the time! It’s almost like you were explaining the value of stories to someone who knew better than you.”

“Shut up. Wait, no. Shut up and then tell me one of your stories.”

“Mixed signals again, babe. But if you insist. Once upon a time-”

“Come on.”

“Alright, alright! I’ll cut to the chase.

Misty was a tired old soul. That's what they said on the mountain, at least. They said he'd lived longer than the numbers counted back, that the things he'd seen fell apart in words or in song. They said all he could explain was that he couldn't explain. He'd talked with gods and lived in squalor and splendor. Man was his clay and his muse, the lands surrounding the mountain painted on his back and chest. They said that Misty knew exactly when he was going to die, and that this knowledge surprised his many friends who were unaware he could die in the first place. He said to them, 'nothing is eternal, and nor am I. Oblivion is the fair deal.' Misty was known on the mountain for his wisdom. He would often comfort those on the mountain in distress with the words, 'there's nothing to fear.' So he had moved to the top of the mountain to die slowly, and when his time came to die quickly, he walked down the hill in ecstatic horror. No one knows what Misty saw on his walk down, in the farlands, where the crevices stretch deeper than the earth and the ridges dispose of visitors with landslides and shadowed creatures. Some said they could guess at what horror would lead Misty to die in the way he did, his face contorted, one eye ripped out. Some said they didn't want to guess-"

"Adora, what kind of fucked up bedtime story… I mean, I can't talk much, but holy shit!"

"Bear with me.

One man, a great beacon of knowledge who had also lived for a long time, though not as long as Misty, dared to investigate Misty's death. See, the mountain was not just a place of refuge. It was a place of science and reason, of godly worship and rational research, of laughter and dance in the evening and happy families in the daytime. There was no shortage of intelligent, compassionate people on the mountain, and as luck would have it, one of them was indeed brave enough. This man, known by many names but to his friends as Thomas, took with him fighting and scientific equipment and descended down the hill. He returned alive with no body but 3 photos and his mind was in tatters. When asked, he would hold the photos of the corpse wordlessly in people's faces and then scream 'I saw nothing. I can't go to sleep' over and over until someone shut him up and sent him in a box down the nice side of the mountain, never to be seen again. Some say that Thomas changed his name and partially recovered, journeying out into the stars. Most couldn't believe that he was even alive, given that whatever horrors had ravaged Misty likely found Thomas as well. A few of the smartest on the mountain noticed the discolouration of Thomas's right hand side, his whole body slightly out of sync. They thought nothing of it.

After that part they- oh, yeah, the story's over. They used to give us a moral lesson, but I'm sure you don't need it."

"You got fucked up bad, didn't you?"

"You could say that." Catra drapes her arms around Adora. It's a loose, noncommittal embrace, but an embrace nonetheless.

"Don't smile about it, you sappy bastard." Catra leaves the embrace awkwardly and settles back into the divot she’s made in

the picnic blanket. She's lost her appetite. "You know, I'm starting to rethink that whole story thing."

"Huh, I wonder why."

"Shut up. But you know what I'm saying. We can write our own stories. To call destiny whatever I like, and to call whatever I like *destiny* . Everything beyond me is *subsumed* by me. I am the *prophet* of my own *soul* ." Catra pronounces certain words with a theatrical flourish, letting loose sly grins as her short performance expands outwards.

"How poetic."

"It's just like your letters."

"I sure hope so." Adora worries she's being noncommittal, but Catra seems content to just talk at the idea of a response rather than deal with a real one. It is only when they go silent again that she pipes up. "Do you like my prose, then?"

"You're fishing for a compliment."

"No, seriously! I put work into the shape of those words. I drew them out of the blank slate."

"I wouldn't call it a blank slate. There's the trees and the leaves and everything alive."

"Then I crown you the *queen* of everything alive!" Adora looks pleased with herself, she knows, but she doesn't mind.

"And is that your language, then? A monarchy for nature. Take the girl out of Brightmoon, eh?"

"I like you, Catra."

"Sure you do."

“No,” and Adora makes sure to space her words with laughter, “I really do.”

“You’re dangerous.”

“Isn’t that a beautiful thing-”

The bombs drop with warning. Adora hears them ten seconds before the rest of the world, her mind diving through a vision at impossible speed, grabbing whatever she can of Catra’s body and shielding her from the blast. It’s a futile effort, but desperately noble. When the dust clears, a void opens in the hot desert of a thousand sudden suns and the grass is torched, the piano at the centre of the field filled with flames. Catra is out cold, her body frail from the unprompted space-time journey that brought them here, and so Adora has to pick her up and carry her limply over her shoulder towards sanctuary. She chose this place for a reason; the piano is not the only sign of life. It is rooted by something alive, as with all tools for music, connected to a living web. Adora follows the scorched paths in the earth away from the bombs, wildlife dying, dead or just flushed in shock out of their natural reverie along the way. She doesn’t want to create her story just yet, given that she barely knows what it’s about, but the sheer tragedy of the blight reminds her of their first letter. Zombies and religious fervour. The bombs are a psychosexual reminder of militaristic godhood. She’s getting lost in the horror. Catra is breathing roughly and shaking her body as she walks. She needs to get out of the open.

Into the trees and under the shifting shade of half-violated greenery in the thick sunlight, Adora picks a path further along the stretch of the piano’s lifeline tether. The music seems to speak with the half-light, and converse with the leaves, and dance with Catra’s sleepy face. Though there is no great sound, and there is no sleep to be found in the shaken landscape, though Adora may have bloodshot eyes from residual dust and a scattered mind full of residual visions and the itching and cloying from all the sweat, though the path seems to stretch forever, they are greeted after hours by a true sanctuary. An opening in a closing. A circle of

trees, a small indigenous population of humanoid figures, and a guitar lying in the centre of it all.

The people on the rim of the circle are holding the tools of a death knell. They come to watch strangers die, or live, in the first sanctuary in the universe. They are a peaceful people with a home full of bones, generations of cemetery workers, and they signal death with bells.

Adora lays Catra down next to the guitar, in the centre of the clearing, while the people watch on, and without even knowing her own mind, picks it up to play. She barely knows any chords, but the ones she can remember will do.

" *Oh, I read somewhere*

That in twenty years

All this experimenting

Will reach its violent end

But I look at you

As we lay and survive

The piano player's playing something with grace

And it's a miracle to be alive

One more time

There's nothing to fear

There's nothing to fear, darling

There's nothing to fear "

Adora's voice is rough and unrehearsed, but something on Catra's ashen face seems to settle when she lets the last line fade away. The song doesn't resolve, and Adora would always get irked when

she heard it as a child, but now she’s hoping that Catra paints in the final chord with the gift of life.

One bell rings.

Adora wonders what it would feel like to float down on this scene, to find the symmetry in the body resting amidst a sea of green, to map out from above the way she melds with nature. To find her up close, a golden flicker of nothingness tousling her hair and turning the tear stains iridescent. It would be nice to float away. Pain is never worth it. But Adora deserves this moment, decides the forest, deserves to see from every angle the soft creature brought into safety by her selfish hand. Pain is never worth it, not when this is so fleeting.

Two bell rings.

So it lasts, and it continues to last, and Adora continues to float on but never away, spiralling around the frail figure of Catra again, learning to understand her. There are no quick flashes, there is no darkness. So it lasts, and in Adora’s mind the painful flows of time start to bend, and every moment is not a consequence of the one prior but now of what follows, the loop breaking at the seams. But as it has to be, under the gaze of a foreign people, the paths of Adora’s memory lead back here. The truest present. A moment that never stops lasting, not even when Catra stirs and her eyelids flutter and her right leg shifts ever so slightly, and doesn’t dare destroy the symmetry but instead builds beauty anew, and when Catra breathes in a little heavier than before Adora thinks she knows the meaning of everything, and she does know the only meaning that matters, and the forest tells her they are mostly the same.

Three bell rings.

The idea was, they would always find each other, even if they never said so. But the threat was never so severe, and if Catra dies, she goes back alone, and stays alone. And Adora can’t bear that burden.

Four bell r-

A violent hacking and spluttering. Catra’s eyes go from peacefully closed to screwed desperately shut to wide open in seconds, consciousness streaming back into her. Adora looks up to an open, emission-streaked sky, the smoke from fires pouring outwards, and inhales a last free breath. She feels awful. Catra undoubtedly feels worse.

"Aaasdfg-A. Ad-ora?"

"Hey. You're okay." She almost phrases it as a question. Catra looks deathly frail.

"That fucked with me. What was that?"

"We got found."

"Well, they fucking missed." Catra knows that the story doesn't track, and Adora’s frowning face isn't much reassurement. The Horde doesn't *miss* , she proved that before, and if Adora is anything to go by, then Brightmoon is at least persistent. More persistent than one wave of poorly aimed bombs. "Hey, Adora?"

"Huh?"

"Was it Brightmoon, then?"

"Maybe. I mean, I could- I saw it all. Maybe it was them."

"It must be. There's no way we would be working on the same communication channels as an enemy agent."

"We?"

"Fuck. Old habits, or whatever," Catra splutters out, an uncomfortable regret colouring her voice.

"Aw, do you feel bad?"

"I was basically dead like 2 minutes ago so please leave the teasing for another time."

"Another time."

"Yeah?"

"Cmon, let's leave. I have some investigating to do."

Adora grabs Catra gently by the arm, hoisting her up and letting her falter slightly. Her body looks gaunt, the energy required to sustain it having been routed to keeping basic bodily functions going. Now she knows their bodies work the same, Adora ponders absently. She should be focused on where exactly to go. With the threat of two agencies looming large, she knows she has to be careful.

“There’s a hospital deep at the heart of the universe. We’re going there.”

“Adora, I’m fine. I’ll get better.”

“You are-”

And with that, it’s Adora who collapses. Catra can only stare wide eyed as the girl who just lifted her up with all the strength in the world falls face first to the floor without a moment’s notice.

“Adora! Wake up!”

Though it pains her aching body to do so, Catra leaps to the floor and puts her head to Adora’s chest. Thank God, her heart still beats strongly, but there’s a nasty shaking to every breath. And then Catra looks up. Her eyes. God, her eyes. Like blue fires, twin suns at the centre of everything. That can’t be good.

With great pain, Catra lifts the much larger, and still shaking, Adora over her shoulders and drags her out of the open space. Though just seconds prior she had been lying safely inside, something tells her that Adora needs to go, to heal somewhere

else, that though she was the one to bring them here, it is not her place to heal. When Catra finally breaks through the treeline and out into the open air, ready to drain herself of any corporeal form once again to power them through non-space, Adora stirs slightly and turns her head to stare glassy eyed at her. “Fuck. It’s me, this time.”

Catra responds in kind, turning her head slowly and with a fearful premonition. If only Adora would stop talking in fucking tongues for a second, she might get a plan together.

“Catra, you can’t get us both out of here. You know you’re too weak.”

“I have to try. I mean, come on. You’re dying.”

“And so are- and so what?”

“I’m sorry?”

“Uh.” Everything sticks in Adora’s throat, her escape from the truth only landing her in different trouble.

“What the fuck does that mean?”

“Nihilism, or- we all die, eh.”

“You know that’s not what nihilism is. You know that’s a sad argument.”

“I can’t, Catra-”

Her eyes close gently, and Catra resigns herself to what will likely be a deadly painful voyage, guided by a delirious and all-too-heavy passenger. Then a torrent of purest spirit, bright blue and totally beyond her conception, takes her off her feet, its source all too obvious. Adora is practically levitating, and turns to face Catra once again with a soul on fire.

“You have to help me.” Her voice is distorted beyond recognition.

“Of course.” Catra dusts herself off and wraps her arm around Adora’s glowing form, and without warning they blink away into the depths of the cosmos.

As she faces the burning spirit, their own rocket fuel through space and time, Catra starts to ponder more than she is usually fond of doing.

"So, Adora, you said you saw it all while the bombing was happening. Does that mean, *all* all, or just the moment in entirety?"

"Catra, if I saw it *all* , then my brain would be fried. Remember the Misty story? And besides, what's the difference?"

"Between what?"

"The whole of a moment, and the whole of everything."

"Probably that we call them two different things."

"And it’s that *illusion* that keeps us sane."

"It's only as illusive as the rest of our perception, and I hate to break it to you, but that's all we've got."

"I hope so."

"Right," murmurs Catra, trailing off at the strangeness of Adora’s remark. The universe rages on past them, stars consumed by the great void of Catra’s own perspective still endlessly at war with the eternity of the cosmos. The Horde gave her human eyes, from two different people they said, and even though what desire flows into them is so past human, the shadows of totalising limitation still have their grip. Adora’s voice once again resounds against her ear, but this time the strange distortion, like the sound of a choir is running into the same frequencies as her lonely old voice, is back.

“We’re here.”

The burning force of spirit slows, the non-space bubble explodes in what Catra can only hope would be a satisfying *pop* , and they tumble once again towards their own prayers for salvation.

They both feel the same deja vu as they fall, except for the terrible sight of what awaits them. The hospital comes into view soon enough, as it takes the shape and size of more a glistening, gleaming city than just one block building amidst a sea of disease, but surrounding it is a teeming, ant-like infestation of battle. War has broken out beneath them. The soldiers scurry like ants on a death drive, blinking in and out of time, a game of life with the prize of total obliteration.

Adora stares in horror. “This is… in my vision, the planet is the ultimate sanctuary.”

“Maybe raging war is good for the skin.”

“The vision said- it said that there was a pharmaceutical bliss, a crawling ecstasy. But it was an old vision, from before I knew they held the future, and I only remembered it because-”

“Don’t tell me. I think everything goes wrong when you tell me things.”

“No, everything goes wrong when I know things, or when I know the truth.”

“Shall we stop guessing, and try to win this time?”

Adora nods as they fall. They have no parachutes this time, but the remnants of Adora’s burning spirit guides them safely to soft ground, away from the horrific mass, but just as far from the hospital city, looming in the distance. Exhausted from the exertion of the journey, Adora goes limp in Catra’s arms, her eyelids flickering, head barely able to support itself.

“No dying today, please.”

THE BATTLE OF HAMPTON ROADS

Chapter Summary

Adora falls asleep. Catra wakes up.

LIGOTTI'S BEEN WAITING UNDER THE MOUNTAIN FOREVER, KEPT ALIVE BY STORIES. HIS SCENT OF SMELL UNDAMAGED BY THE ROT AND THE GRIME, HIS EYES FALLING OUT OF HIS HEAD, THE PIECES OF HIS FRIENDS AROUND HIM, RESENTMENT AND PRECISION HAVE CULMINATED IN TRUE MADNESS.

LIGOTTI SMELLS THE TWO HEADED GIRL. HE HAS TO PLAY CALM.

To be exact, Catra notes that the hospital lies at the foot of the mountain, beyond a valley. Strewn across Catra's sinewy arms, Adora beckons with a subconscious desire to the pearly white automatic doors that greet them across the valley. But in front rages the great storm of bloodlust, obscuring the doors in great waves that collide and mutate in unison like the slicing up of a tsunami.

LIGOTTI EATS AT THE BLOODLUST, LAPS AT ITS CRIMSON EDGES, DESPERATE FOR MORE. SOMETHING ABOUT HIM HAS DRAWN THE BATTLE CLOSE, AT THE HAMPTON CROSSROADS, TO THE RIGHT OF HIS GRAVE, TO THE LEFT OF THE CASTLE. UP THE HILL, DESTINY RUBS ITS GLEEFUL HANDS TOGETHER.

Catra is still struggling from the bombing injuries, her body long since untethered from The Horde's basic sustenance implemented just in case an agent gets trapped. This time, there's no assumption that Catra is simply lost or trapped - at the very least, she knows that Hordak knows she was always desperate to get away, and they had been tracking Adora at least more than Catra had planned for, so it's no surprise to her that her body is stuck on life support. Her thoughts are coming at hyperspeed now, as the valley looms large beyond them. Adora struggles and groans, her

body constantly slipping, legs barely able to move. The blue glow is coming in flutters now, weak and buzzing with leaking spirit. It's terrifying to watch her slip away. So Catra powers forward, completely unsure as to how to cross the turmoil of battle. Even when connected with The Horde, even with her strongest possible physical form, the extent of the battle, an endless swirling mass of faceless creatures, helmets adorned and melee weapons swung with wild violence, would have been beyond her reckoning. Something truly horrible is stuck within these people. Someone has given them the ultimate death drive.

Dragging Adora's limp body down through the valley, Catra keeps powering forward, stopping to think at the edge of the turmoil. It's bizarre that it even has an edge, that at some point, the blood stops spilling. A naturally occurring non-space, she realises, and the edge of violence. A universe that'll rip you apart, fingertips from your face. She turns and whispers to Adora.

"Where does it hurt?"

Adora finds the strength to reply.

"The hospital… they…"

"They what? Adora, come on! I'm scared here!"

"You- alw-" Adora cuts herself off with a hacking cough. "Always were."

"It's not like that. I'm scared- you're gonna disappear."

"Beautiful." And with that, her eyes go back to being screwed tightly shut, the blue glow leaking and spilling out in pieces. Catra sighs dejectedly and stares out across the ignorant swath of war-scorched land, the battle still raging. In the absence of anything better to do, she lays Adora down gently and takes a seat next to her on a small mound to the left of where they had first descended into the valley, and there they wait.

The battle shows no signs of stopping. Catra starts to debate whether waiting was the worst idea she's ever had, amidst a litany of worryingly recent bad ideas. She thinks that the only good idea she had was pulling out of that kiss at the concert, the kiss with the girl now prostate and barely alive next to her. The girl glowing a pale shade of green. Fuck.

It's in her veins. She's probed, poked, opened screwed-shut eyes and done everything else she can think of without basic medical equipment, but Catra is stumped as to the nature of Adora's disease. It's mutating, that's for sure, but *from* where and *to* where is a mystery.

LIGOTTI CAN SMELL HER BODY DEGRADING. HE TRAVELS THROUGH THE BLOOD MIST, FINDING IN THE PRIMAL RAGE OF ITS RELEASE ENERGY THE CORPOREAL FORM HE HAS LOST FOR EONS. OR, CLOSE ENOUGH.

A great shadow pulls out of the dirt. Catra doesn't know how to react, or where to go, so she sits patiently as the haze of blood and the stench of gore coalesce in front of her and Adora's shaking body. Instinctively, she drapes two gaunt arms in front of Adora's face, a futile shield from the worst of *something* . It starts to grow a face. The dust and grime joins the fun, spiralling like water and oil thrown into a sink, particles repelling themselves around forever. A brownish-black smear on the fabric of being, an illusive non-thing. Catra remembers a few stories, and this is the worst of it. The black hole spectre. She knows it from her dig amidst the lighthouse archives to be the ghost of Ligotti.

" **Oh. Both of you. It's my lucky day.** "

When Ligotti speaks, the words form into the symphony of screaming stars. A language for the sun that takes forever to die, an echo from the immense tomb.

"I know you, somehow."

" **Good. I've known you both since forever, we just never got to meet. I am the ghost of Ligotti, your black hole spectre, the prophet and evangelist of the end of the world.** "

"Are you a God?"

" **His nasty side. The part that made Him want to die.** "

"So not quite. Then why introduce yourself?"

" **Adora's mind is degrading at a fantastic pace. That she can stay shaking there is a miracle. I need her to hear that I have come to save her.** "

"I would guess you are here to make a deal." Catra stares down what passes for the shadow's eyes.

" **Something like it. I am here to take you from the hope of the hospital to the castle, to complete your reason of being and non-being, and thus complete the synthesis of the two. Towards eternity.** "

"But we don't need to know that."

" **Ah, naivety. Your choice both exists and non-exists, doesn't it? You hate your power yet you demand it? Well listen Catra, I need your choice to be exact here. For one precise moment you must transcend the dialectic, and become singular. Chaos demands unity. Subsumption demands transcendence.** "

"Take me to the hospital. With her. I don't know how, but I'm sure you can, so fucking go. Even you don't want her dead, right?"

" **Not quite yet, but no. I'll hold her in stasis. Give me a second.** " The form flickers and for a moment Catra resigns herself to victory. Then it all goes black.

"Oh fuck."

" **This is a non-space.** "

"I was in one an hour ago, so fucking *no it isn't.* "

" **What you call non-space is actually just a projection of non-space into space in a partially rarefied form. Rarefied enough, you get conventional space. Pure space is non-existent.** "

"And this is different how?"

" **Well, it remains a projection, but it is coming from the source.** "

"And that would be you."

" **Close enough. The Horde and Brightmoon speak for aspects of perception; they are phenomenological. I speak for aspects of space; I am epistemological. Hegelian non-space, as you agents call it, is a phenomenological projection. This is a Spinozist non-space, a horrible place, an epistemological projection.** "

Catra lets the words dance around her tired mind and takes in what she can.

"So it's just a different non-space."

" **It is better. I am not restrained by dimension, as dimension emerges from navigation emerges from perception. I can appear wherever I like, and it was the death of millions that gave me the strength to do it. A battle once orchestrated by your Horde and her Brightmoon.** "

"This is us?" Catra gestures to where the war was, only a minute ago. Adora still lies, mostly braindead on the floor.

" **Yes. I ran the show of course. And soon, the two sides will disintegrate, and all will be a death spiral without**

reason in anyone's mind. A black hole in the spirit of all things. ″

"And you're making Adora do that."

″ **In a way. She's the two headed girl. Brightmoon fed her false memories that became true, hewn from the chaos within you, which I bled into myself. See! The poetry in your love is from the same fabric as the eternity of my suffering slumber! Look what desire has wrought!** ″

The sound at the end of his moment of manic horror nearly tears through Catra's eardrums, an omnidirectional drone from within the heart of a black hole.

″ **Come with me, and take her beside you. In her birthplace, she will be born, and she will die again. You will see a light three times, and the choking feeling in your soul will loosen forever.** ″

"But the choking keeps me alive. Choking on the sick stream of life is refreshing after a long, long time."

″ **You never believed that. But it seems I've failed.** ″

The non-space dissolves. A hospital to the left, a path away and up the mountain to the right. The war melted into itself behind them. A great blur spread out across the scene. It speaks for the last time.

"**One last try. You'll give up now, Catra. Her death spells the death of all things. There's no smart option but to fade away beside her.**″

"But *she* can't die!" Catra's voice is hoarse, her cries to the wind. The spectre of Ligotti shows no shock or anger.

″ **She has to go.** ″

“But I need her, and I can only need if we live. I can only need if the Horde and Brightmoon stay at war. I can only need her if we keep running. I can only need *her* if every day she can hear me play the piano before we go to bed. There’s a hotel room in the sunset with our name on it, and I’ll be damned if your petrid excuse for a ceasefire placates me.”

“ **Give her up, Catra.”**

“Big mistake. Don’t tell me what I have to fucking do!”

Catra screams into nothingness.

“Fine, then. She’ll die on my terms.”

And she turns, and runs.

TWO HEADED GIRL PT.2

Chapter Summary

"And out into the aching sun, so painfully alive"

Before breaking the seal of the hospital doors, Catra roots around at the base of the mountain for something she can just barely sense. Phased through non-space powered by the sheer force of Adora's now-faded spirit, the path of the music still echoes here. And in a scrapheap pile nearby a great chasm that looms just beneath where the ground picks up towards the ascent, a guitar rests. Battered, bruised and ringing with potential. Catra picks it up and straps it to her back, carefully circling the gaping chasm. Adora rests against a pointed outcrop of rock, her body in an even worse state after being carried on Catra's shoulder out of the non-space and towards the exit, tossed about as she beats away stragglers of an increasingly messy and uncontained battle. Catra knows her time is short. She picks up Adora's body again, this time with just one screaming arm, and throws her through the hospital doors, the staff inside hurrying about behind glass and scavenging for weapons. A place of peace forced into war. Catra puts the guitar on her back and stands in front of the door, as strong as she's ever felt, as alone as she'll ever be, waiting for the tidal wave.

It never notices her. She lets the bodies pass over her, like a mosh pit or a march to the sea, and turns around, defeated joyously.

The intense chaos rages just outside the hospital window. The feeling is amniotic. She doesn't want to know anymore. Catra walks, guitar on her back, towards Adora's room with grace and a surreal bliss, her eyes already wet.

"Good evening, my two headed girl. Is it cold in that bed?"

Adora lies, strewn, dying, across soft sheets, safe and clean. Machines click beside her, the ill-fitting gown dishevelled by radio

wires, her face still and serene.

“You better not have died on me already.”

Adora doesn’t snap awake, every aching muscle in her body simply too worn to try, but Catra’s rasp sets her brain alight.

“Catr-”

She cuts herself off with a hacking cough and the salt of her tears.

“Look, just shut up. Okay? You talk like no one’s listening, I know, but please. Let me speak.”

Adora moves achingly to protest but nothing comes. She resigns to her bedsheets, feeling the gentle compression of Catra taking a seat beside her.

“Catra, I’m scared.”

“I know.”

“Can’t you-” another, more violent cough, “-do something. Help me. Or hurt me, I don’t know.”

“How did one of your eyes go so gray?”

“Doctors don’t know. My biology isn’t really normal, is it? I don’t know what I’d call myself anymore. Ha! I’m free.”

“I told you to shut up.”

“You weren’t saying anything.”

Catra shushes her with a finger and a watery smile.

“I brought this.” And Catra takes a guitar off her back as she speaks. “You wanted to hear me sing.”

Adora can’t bring herself to feel anything more than a sheer weight, a great ineffability of desire.

“What will you sing for me, lover girl?”

Catra smiles again, no sharp teeth, just bright bright white, and sets the guitar on her lap, arching her back and breathing in shakily.

“And in my dreams you're alive and you're cryin'

As your mouth moves in mine soft and sweet

Rings of flowers round your eyes and I love you

For the rest of your life when you're here.”

Adora is breathing quietly during the first verse. She sees Catra close her eyes at the high notes, sees her clawless fingers cross the fretboard with a practiced elegance, sees the smile at the corner of her mouth when she says “I love you”.

“Brother, see we are one in the same

And you left with your head filled with flames

And you watched as your brains fell out through your teeth

Push the pieces in place, make your smile sweet to see

Don't you take this away, I'm still wanting my face on your cheek.”

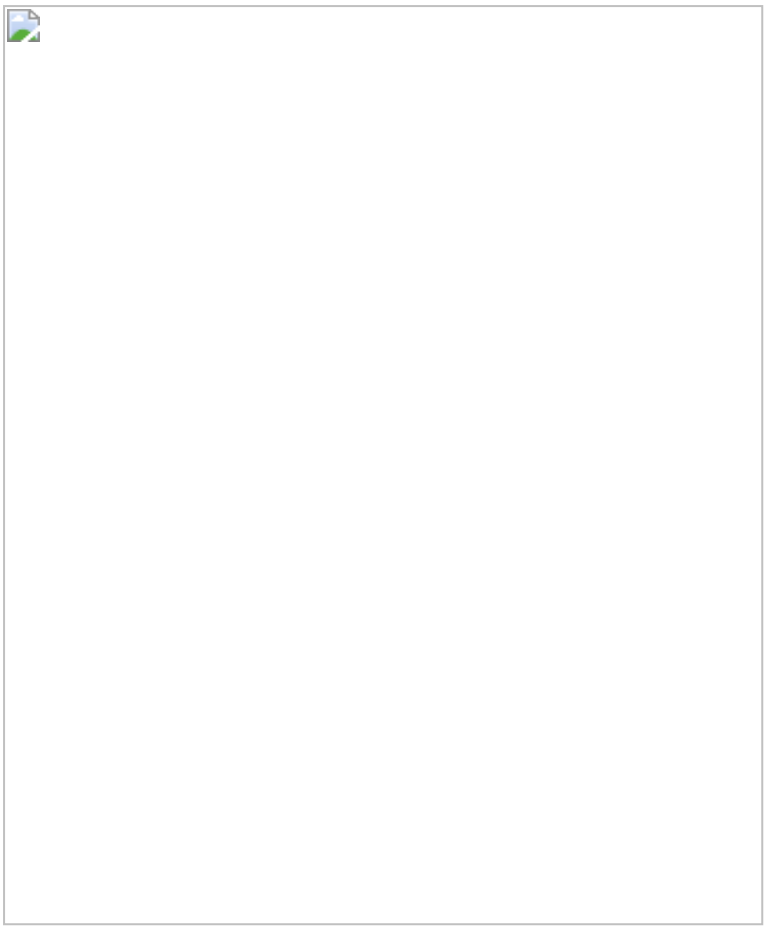
As Catra gets louder, as her voice starts to falter on the longest words, Adora feels her own body start to fail too. Her hands and arms are engulfed by a violent light that shoots up out of the floors and meets the ceiling, then the sky, in icy harmony.

“And when we break, we'll wait for our miracle

God is a place where some holy spectacle lies

When we break, we'll wait for our miracle

God is a place you will wait for the rest of your life."



Catra screams out the word "God" like she is in the word itself and it is the last thing Adora ever hears.

"But don't hate me when I get up to leave."

She knows when she has ended the song that Adora is dead. The gasping and shuffling had stopped when she screamed. Catra drags a hand across a face bathing in light and falling away into ash. The first thing Adora ever knew of her - the ashen forest, the claws, and the way she wouldn't leave those blue eyes alone.

Catra gets up quietly to leave. Her tears and sweat have made the sheets warm and wet, though there is nothing anymore for them to cling to. As the dust flies past Catra's face and beyond towards

the horizon, the last words of an eternal desire are painted onto her brain. Adora's last letter.

Dearest Catra,

Our game is up. We lost.

We wanted to grow old, really. Some magic mountain to walk down instead of screaming blissfully atop, some context, an ending that made sense. But the fact is, you have enough endings for me. All I'll miss are the beginnings. Catra, I'm so sorry. I-

Catra cannot bring herself to finish the letter. She runs through a hospital corridor that she is too tired to recognise, and out into the aching sun, so painfully alive.

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